The Shape of You

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

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Alternate Universe, Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Fantasy, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting, Shapeshifting, Alternate Universe - Shapeshifters

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by lologoblens

Summary

Adora transplants to the country after her Grandmother's death. One dark and stormy night, alone and lonely, Adora finds a stray kitten on her doorstep. When she lets them inside she has no idea just exactly what she's inviting into her life.

On My Doorstep

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora's heart is broken, irreparable even. Rain patters against her window and the wind howls. Most nights, as she attempts to fall asleep, Adora howls too. She sits at the kitchen island, despondent, and stares at the bouquet in the center;dark crimson roses interspersed with a rainbow of gladiolus. They're beautiful and still, Adora hates them for what they represent.

She startles when the pittering of rain is interrupted by a sound at her back door. A frantic scratching assaults her ears. She stands and circles the island to the other side of the kitchen, peeking out the curtain in the window of the door. There seems to be nothing there, but just to be sure she opens the door and peeks out. There, meek and soaked through with rain, is a small kitten. Adora gasps.

"Hey kitten, do you want to come inside?"

The kitten, a dark brown with lighter stripes, likely made darker by the rain, looks up at her and mewls pathetically. Their eyes catch Adora's and she's briefly startled by how alert the gaze is. They're also quite beautiful;heterochromatic, one a bright ocean blue and the other a warm gold. The rain slows from torrential to steady.

Adora opens the door wider and steps out of the way. "Your call, but the heater is on and I probably have some tuna or something I can share."

She watches the kitten who looks back suspiciously. Adora just waits patiently. After another, slightly huffy meow the kitten walks past her and into the house. It stops a few paces in and looks back at her expectantly .

Adora digs a towel out of a nearby drawer and crouches down in front of them. "May I?"

Another distrustful glance and the kitten trots closer. They look cute when she's finished drying them off, all ruffled and puffy. They're positively indignant at her giggling.

"There, come with me." She leads them into the den and starts a fire in the hearth. Once she's worked it up to roaring, she calls over to the kitten who waits in the doorway. "Would you like to come warm up?"

They give her a shrewd look, glance at the couch significantly, and look back. Adora follows their gaze and raises and eyebrow. She picks up a soft blanket and raises it in askance. The kitten mewls appreciatively and meets her at the hearth, where she makes a nest from the blanket. They make themselves comfortable and look at her expectantly again.

"Hungry?"

The mewl back at her, a light purr starting in their chest.

She laughs. "You're a pretty demanding houseguest, you know?"

They purr louder.

Adora rolls her eyes, smiling despite herself. "Alright, you're right, I did offer." She retreats back to the kitchen to search for an appropriate meal for a cat. While she fills a small dish with tuna, she looks out the window; for the first time in a week it isn't raining.

The kitten looks up lazily from the nest, the purr beginning anew when the see Adora returning with food. She sets it, and a dish of water, beside them. They take their time getting up to get it but wolf it down the moment they start eating. Adora's glad to see it, they're decidedly on the skinny side.

While they're making themselves comfortable Adora picks up a novel and begins to read. She's surprised when, a half hour later, the kitten comes to make themselves comfortable on her stomach. She smiles down at them and scratches their head absently while she reads. Soon they start to purr and knead gently into the blanket covering her belly.

That night Adora goes to bed with the kitten curled tightly on the pillow beside her. When she wakes up in the morning they've already gone.

A few days later Adora wakes up to a foggy day, the air is thick and hazy with it. She spends her morning keeping busy;she' s not really sure what to do with so much time to herself. By default, she does what she would if Razz were there with her;she bakes. She peels her apples, mixes a crust, and remembers the good days. How full an light Razz could make this home. When she goes to lay her lattice, she realizes a light, warm rain has washed away the fog and she smiles at the change.

By the time she pulls the pie from the oven the rain has stopped, and the air is permeated with petrichor. Adora decides a cool walk followed by a warm slice of pie sounds just about perfect. She pulls on her wellies and a jacket and she' s off.

On autopilot, she wanders down the country lane behind the house. It leads her behind a few small farms, and she greets the chickens and goats as she passes, lingering to whisper with Swift Wind;the neighbor's horse.

As she turns to walk back, she's greeted by the sight of the little kitten from the rainstorm. They sit primly, staring her down, head tilted to the side.

"Hey you. You disappeared so fast, I'm glad to see you're safe."

The kitten mewls at her and Adora is sure if they were capable, she'd be getting their eyes rolled at her . The thought just makes her giggle.

"Well either way, it's good to see you." She nods politely at them and wanders back toward the house. She's surprised when the kitten walks alongside her. They continue to follow her even as she walks through the back gate into Raz's garden. "Oh, so are you coming over?"

The little cat doesnt even deign to respond, instead running the final few steps up to the back door. Adora lets the both of them in and watches in amusement at the kitten sniffs the air, seeming to relax at the smell of the warm pie. Then they hop onto the counter to sniff it directly and she laughs aloud.

"Excuse me!"

The cat mewls and Adora can practically hear them scoff at her.

"Hm, house rule; no feet on the counters, sorry kitten."

The cat holds her gaze and lifts a paw to start cleaning it. Adora laughs again, she feels the sun warm the back of her neck where it filters in through the window.

"Well, I guess you're making an effort at least. Would you like more tuna?"

The cat sniffs snootily, drops their paw and sniffs at the pie again.

"The pie? I'm not so sure pie is very good for cats."

The answering meow she gets back is downright snooty.

Adora puts her hands up defensively. "Alright, you know what? I'm not your mom, do what you want." She cuts two slices of pie and sits down at the counter. To her amazement the kitten finishes their whole slice faster than she does. Though, to be fair, she is rather

distracted;shocked at seeing a kitten sitting on her counter munching happily away at a slice of her late grandmother's signature pie.

Adora cleans the dishes from their meal while the kitten remains on the counter, cleaning their paws and behind their ears. She wonders when it was that they last had a good meal. They really are too skinny;shell have to keep that in mind. Once she' s finished with the dishes Adora leads them into the den and she spends another afternoon reading until the sun goes down.

The kitten sits with her for a while before growing restless. Eventually moving to look out the window. At first Adora assumes they're watching the birds that nest in the tree out front. However, when she really pays attention, she gets the impression that's not actually it. They seem to be on high alert, scanning the yard and surrounding land. It puts Adora ever so slightly on edge, but she tries not to worry herself too much over it.

The next morning when she wakes up the kitten is still curled up on the pillow beside hers. Adora hums, sighing off the lingering lethargy, and stretches her arms above her head. Beside her the kitten lets out a yawn that has Adora cooing over their cuteness;they seem to enjoy the attention. When she scratches behind their ear , they lean into it so hard they nearly topple over.

There's a smile in Adora's voice when she greets them with a soft, "Morning kitten."

The kitten tilts it's head, regarding her mildly. They still look sleepy, long slow blinks acting as their only response.

"I'm going to the kitchen, are you coming?" She stands and throws sweats on over the underwear she'd worn to bed, and a cardigan over her tank top. When she turns back to the bed the kitten is watching her. "What?"

They just purr loudly at her.

"Alright," Adora chuckles. "Let's go." She leads them into the kitchen and surveys her fridge. She looks over to the kitten who has made themselves comfortable on her kitchen island again. They look up from cleaning a back paw when she turns to them. "What do you think, too early for pie or?"..

Adora takes their increased purring as encouragement and the both of them have a slice of pie for breakfast. After they've finished, Adora takes care of some chores around the house. The kitten follows her around for a little bit but quickly grows bored of her shenanigans. They prowl around until they find a patch of sun in the den and stretch out, settling in for a nap.

Eventually Adora realizes the time and crouches down beside them to stroke their head gently. "Hey kitten, I've gotta go out for a little bit. You're welcome to stay, but if you don't want to be locked in for the next few hours, I'm leaving in ten."

When she leaves the house fifteen minutes later the kitten is still snoozing away, soaking up the sun. Adora's errands are mundane; groceries, a stop at the bank and a pick up at the pharmacy. All told it take her about an hour and a half before she's returning home. The minute she opens the front door the kitten streaks past her.

"Oh, okay. Bye! Hopefully I see you later." The last part she mostly says to herself; the kitten has already disappeared around the corner of the house. She unloads her groceries, cursing herself when she finds no salt in the cupboard. "Looks like I'll be going back into town sooner than I thought." She mutters to herself at the discovery.

That night, chores done and a proper meal prepared, Adora curls up in front of the TV and wonders if maybe she should get an actual pet. She's lonely, the house is big and quiet; nearly cavernous with the feeling of unfillable energy. She hadn't realized how nice it was having another living person in the house. And after all, she'd always

wanted a dog. She goes to bed, alone and undecided, scrolling through the local animal shelter's website on her phone.

The next morning, she wakes up to a strange, scratchy feeling at her ear. When she swipes at it, she's greeted with an affronted mewl. Adora scrambles back on the bed and puts a hand on her chest to steady her racing heart. It's just the kitten. Does that mean they were what? Cleaning her ear? *That's kinda sweet…*

"Hey kitten, how did you get in here?"

The kitten gives her a look and hops onto the window sill. Ah, of course; she'd left the window cracked last night.

"I see, well welcome back. Should I be worried? Do you have a family looking-"

The kitten hisses, a look of betrayal in their eyes, and hops out the window. Adora scurries over and sees them stalking away. The wind kicks up and tussles their fur this way and that in a chaotic dance.

"I'm sorry, I didn't mean to offend you!" She huffs and starts muttering to herself. "And *I* am calling after a damn stray cat. Get it together Adora"…

And so, she does. Sort of. She still has no idea what to do with herself with so much time on her hands. After she found out Raz had left her the house and a small nest egg along with it, she'd quit her job and left the city without question. She knows she needs to find a way to occupy her time, and that eventually it would be wise to start generating income again. She just doesn't know what that looks like.

For now, she heads to the garden. Autumn is settling in and she tends to the few seedlings she'd planted the week after she moved. There are leaves to be raked and a few other odds and ends. She's

cold to her bones after she's through and so heads inside for a warm bath. She spends nearly the whole time wondering about the kitten. Perhaps she does need some form of company.

Clothed and dried she dials up Glimmer's number. Glimmer answers almost immediately, her face popping up on Adora's screen.

"*There* you are! We were beginning to think maybe you had no reception out there in the boonies."

"We?" Bow's face pops into the frame at her clarification and he waves. "Oh! Hey Bow."

"Hey Adora! How are things going out there?"

She shrugs. "Fine, it's slow out here."

"Isn't that what you wanted?" His brow furrows in concern.

"It is!" She insists. "It's just a lot of time with myself, you know?"

Both her friends nod compassionately. "No old friends to look up?" Glimmer prompts.

Adora snots and shakes her head. "Not exactly. The neighbors had me over for dinner my first week. They're sweet but it was… awkward. They spent the whole time trying to console me about, well, you know. I haven't exactly wanted to rush back over."

Bow's brows knit even more tightly together. "I don't know that I like you all alone out there…"

Glimmer starts nodding along before he's even finished. "Totally! Are you sure you don't want to come home? Maybe Raz's could be more of a retreat space for you."

Adora smiles a little sadly and shakes her head. "Nah, I never took to the city like you two. Honestly, it's a little boring but I feel way more relaxed than I ever did in Brightmoon. And I did make one friend!"

"Oh! Exciting, who?" Adora's face heats up a titch at Glimmer's enthusiasm.

"Well I mean it's a cat." Adora does *not* like the look that garners. "I was kidding! Kind of, I mean there is a cat."

"Adora"…

"Stars Glimmer, I know that's not a replacement for human interaction. Why do you think I'm calling you?"

Glimmer snorts at her. "Well, glad to hear you haven't totally lost your grip on reality."

"Gee, thanks. So anyway what's new there?"

"Well, nothing as exciting as a visit from a *cat*-"

"Glimmer!"

"but my dad's coming into town next week."

"Aw! Tell Micah hi' from me, I'm sorry to miss him."

"I'm sure he says, hi' back, but I'll keep you posted." Bow gives a little chuckle at that. "Oh! And Bow has news."

Bow beams at this. "My boss approved my vacation time! So, we can come visit you the first week of October, if that still works for you?"

Adora is genuinely thrilled at this news. "That's great! How long do you think you'll stay for?"

"I got a week off, including travel days."

"Sounds great, wish you guys could stay forever though."

"You and me both!" Glimmer exclaims dramatically. "You won't *believe* what happened at work the other day." From there Glimmer

launches into a long tirade about the ineptitude of her coworkers that pretty much takes up the rest of the time they have to chat.

After they hang up Adora has a quiet night, eating a quiet dinner, in her quiet house. It's peaceful if nothing else.

The kitten doesn't turn up again for four days. By the time they do Adora's so bored she's been in to town three times for totally unnecessary errands. On the bright side, she has a cat bed now. You know, just in case. The kitten recoils initially at her excitement.

"Sorry, sorry!" She tells them, registering their unease. "It's been… quiet here. I've never lived alone before." She starts muttering to herself as she walks toward the den. "Maybe I should get a pet, clearly I need someone to"…

That's when Adora registers the kitten has stopped halfway to the den. Their hair is beginning to stand on end and they're emitting a low growl. Adora smirks and props a hand on her hip.

"Don't tell me you're getting territorial? You don't even live here."

The kittens growl lessens to a low rumble and, keeping eye contact with Adora the entire time, they begin scent marking her furniture. Adora's not sure she's ever laughed so hard in her entire life. She's bent over at the waist before all is said and done. The entire time the kitten continues to mark her possessions as their own.

She follows them as they head into the den, pausing to mark the doorway. "Alright, I get the point! I'll hold off on a pet for now. But I gotta have *someone* to talk to when you go off galivanting, doing goddess only knows what."

The kitten chirrups and winds between her legs.

"Okay , now I got something while you were away ." She indicates the little cat bed, positioned between the fireplace and the couch. She's also gotten a couple toys which lay in the bed and a water dish which she's left beside it. "What do you think kitten?"

The kitten looks initially surprised. They stop short and stare at the new additions to the room. Adora watches them turn to survey her. Seemingly satisfied their chest erupts with a rumbling purr and they take one bounding leap into the bed. The way they roll around in it has Adora giggling like a little girl.

"W ell, I m glad you like it." The kitten rolls of f the bed and trots over to boop their head against her shin. The gesture fills Adora's heart with warmth and glee. She crouches down to their level and hold out her arms hesitantly. "I know we haven't ever could I pick you up?"

The kitten stares at her for a while. She doesn't dare to hope but is still a bit disappointed when they opt to turn around and get comfortable in their new bed. They're purring harder than ever though, and she takes that as a good sign.

After that the kitten doesn't stay away so long again. T ypically, they leave the house for no more than an hour or so. The notable exceptions being when Adora leaves the house also and they run out before she can lock them in. Once, a few weeks after Adora presents the bed, they actually hop in her truck with her and ride into town.

Adora slides out once they've reached the market and grabs her grocery bags. "Are you okay to stay in here? I don't think the market's gonna- well okay then." Q uickly bored of Adora' s rant, the kitten has already found a little cranny under a seat to curl up in. Adora laughs and locks the car behind her.

She doesn't need much from the store, but she was wiped out on basics. That tiny, little kitten eats a surprising amount. And they

always, without fail insist on whatever Adora is having.

She has an idea or two about what a vet might say about that, but they're a little stray country cat. She's sure that her relatively healthy and simple diet *has* to be better than whatever they'd pick up in the streets if she refused to share. If they could even find enough to eat. They're already looking healthier-more filled out, their coat shinier than ever-after just a few weeks hanging around the house. And regardless of all her reasons, they're *awfully* insistent.

With that in mind she picks up a little extra of the things she's been going through extra quickly. She's got all she needs and is standing in the bakery section, doing her best to talk herself out of a pack of very delicious looking cupcakes, when someone sidles up next to her. Something about the presence sends a shiver up Adora's spine. She does her best not to show it but has no way to know how successful she is.

Ready to turn around without any treats, just to get away from this stranger's domineering presence, Adora is interrupted by their voice.

"Strange weather we've been having lately, isn't it Unseasonably… warm." They say it like some extra sunny days are the worst possibility they could hope to come up with.

"Uh Is suppose so. I haven't lived here since I was pretty young, I guess I don't remember what's usual."

The stranger, even taller than Adora with an impressive shroud of dark hair, sizes Adora up with a shrewd look. She feels herself relax minutely when they finish their silent assessment. "I see, well then; welcome back. I'm sure I'll see… seeing you around."

And then they just walk away, leaving a shell shocked Adora behind. That was… ominous to say the least. She shakes it off and steers her cart toward the check out. The cakes remain on the shelf, forgotten entirely in Adora's haste. She's eager to get in the car when she's

through. She shoves her bags into the back and is rambling before she's even shut the door.

"You know kitten, small town charm is all well and good but-hey, are you okay?"

The kitten mewls pathetically from the base board on the passenger's side. Their tail is roughly three sizes too poufy and they look beyond terrified.

"Aw, hey kitten, you're okay! Did a dog walk by and spook ya or something?" Adora leans down and offers her hands but the kitten continues to cower in place. "Okay, I'm gonna get us home, alright?" She does as promised and promptly gets the car going.

About halfway home she hears a scuffle beside her as the kitten pulls themselves up onto the bench seat beside her. Slowly they crawl until they're on her lap, posture tense. Adora stays purposefully relaxed, letting them settle without intervention. After a few minutes they do lay down, still not fully relaxed but kneading tightly into the thigh of her jeans.

"Hey little kitten, feeling a bit better?"

They don't react beyond a low, almost inaudible purr. It seems to Adora to be more a sound of self-soothing than of pleasure.

They're home in no time at all and Adora gets her bags loaded into her arms. The kitten hesitates at the edge of the seat and Adora waits patiently. Still, when they make no move to hop down, she prompts them. "Are you coming inside kitten?"

They don't look at her.

"Do you want me to carry you?"

That gets more of a reaction; the kitten peers at her face, tilting their head to the side. They stay like that, in this weird stalemate of sorts,

until the kitten seems to make a snap decision. The let out a quick meow and then hop out, racing to the door.

Adora follows after, still a touch concerned and lets them both in. When the kitten doesnt leave the house once for three weeks Adora doesnt comment, but she certainly notices. She cant complain about the company though.

The first week of October Adora peeks at her calendar. She looks over to the kitten who is bathing on the counter, a habit she cant seem to break them of.

"Hey kitty, we've got company coming."

That gets their attention, they almost seem to harrumph at the news.

"My best friends from college are coming, Im excited to see them. I think youll like them, Bow especially. Glimmer's great too! A little excitable though, Iknow that's not usually a cat sort of vibe." She chuckles remembering the number of cats she's seen Glimmer alienate over the years with her exuberance.

The kitten practically rolls their eyes.

"Alright sassy, well youll have to play nice for the week, okay?"

A short chirrup and the kitten hops down from the counter, lazily stalking out of the room.

With a laugh in her voice she calls after them. "Im taking that as a yes, just so you know!"

Bow and Glimmer insist on renting a car so they can drive themselves from the airport. Adora is secretly relieved, it's by no

means a short drive. Between that and their flight she sees the car roll up in her driveway around eight that evening.

"They're here!" She announces to the room at large the moment they pull up. She hops up from the couch where she's been keeping a vigil since they texted her that they'd landed and runs out the door. "Hey guys!"

"*Adora!*" Her friends both scurry out from the car and rush over to scoop her into a hug. She's smooshed between them, arm bent awkwardly around Glimmer's shoulders, and happier than she's been in months.

"Come inside, it's well it's actually kind of nice. It's been freezing all week."

"Weird." Bow comments with a quirk of his lips. "You know the forecast did say there was a cold front heading this way."

"You looked up the forecast?" Adora tilts her head, grabbing Glimmer's suitcase from her and leading them into the house.

"Well yeah, had to know what to pack." Glimmer leans behind him to mouth the word *'Virgo'* to Adora. She covers a laugh with the back of her hand.

"Ahem, well seems like it may have been in vain, sorry Bow."

"No worries, I've got layers!"

Adora lets her next laugh out freely as she locks the door behind them. "Sick, well lemme show you to the guestroom and you guys can settle in. Do you want any tea or hot cocoa or anything?"

"Ooh, tea would be great!" Bow answers.

"Cocoa for you Glim?"

Glimmer shoots a wicked grin her way as she slips past into the guestroom. "You know it."

With a nod Adora leads them to it and heads to the kitchen. She hears the kitten hop up onto the counter behind her as she sets the kettle to boil on the stove. She turns to face them, raising an eyebrow in surprise. "Didn't expect to see too much of you tonight. Where've you been all day?"

They mewl innocently at her like they hadn't run off to hide somewhere after lunch.

"Uh-huh, are you gonna have tea with us or are you not feeling social tonight?"

The kitten flops onto their back dramatically, rolling around a little for good measure. Adora laughs loudly at the display.

"Always so dramatic. Do you want that rose with a bit of cream again?"

The roll to lay on their side and make a short, affirmative sound. Adora nods and sets out mugs with tea for Bow and the kitten, and cocoa for Glimmer and herself. When she pulls out the whip cream the kitten lets out a plaintive meow.

"Wow, give me half a second, would you?"

The kitten sniffs and she rolls her eyes at the drama of it all. Still she smiles down at them as she sprays a dollop of whip cream onto the counter.

"You're a real piece of work, you know that Kitten?"

They ignore her and continue to lap up their treat.

"Adora? Who are you talking-" Bow turns the corner and stops short when he sees the scene in front of him. He practically melts on the

spot and the best way Adora can think to describe his expression is "heart eyes."

The kitten looks at him sharply with narrowed eyes.

"Oh, this is the kitten that hangs out, remember I told you?"

"I knew you got a cat; I just didn't think *I'd get to meet them on night one*!" Adora mutters under her breath something about she didn't *really* 'get' a cat, but it goes ignored. "What's their name?"

"Oh, uh... they don't really have one, I guess? Not that I know of anyway."

Glimmer snorts as she walks into the room, automatically grabbing the kettle when it starts to whistle as she walks past. "I can't believe you haven't bothered to name your cat Adora."

The kitten, who had tensed up with Glimmer's arrival now hisses indignantly at her.

Glimmer looks offended but Bow just laughs at the predictable sight. Adora gives Glimmer a look but turns to address the kitten first. "Hey, remember how I said you have to play nice this week? I'd appreciate if you didn't hiss at my friends."

The kitten stares at her obstinately for a moment but then relaxes. They start cleaning a paw like they couldn't care less about the whole exchange. Adora scoffs and rolls her eyes at the put-on air of aloofness.

"You talk to that thing like they're a human Adora."

Adora turns to scowl at Glimmer. "Hey, if they have to play nice so do you." It doesn't escape Adora the way the kitten's purr rumbles to life at this order. "I may not have a name but that thing's kinds mean Glim. And they're not *my cat*, okay? They're just like a... freeloading roommate."

Bow snorts. "Adora, what do you think a pet is?" He inclines his head to the den in a silent suggestion and they make their way to settle in on the couches. The kitten waits until they've fully settled in before coming to sit on Adora's lap.

"Okay , okay, maybe. Idont know , Idont keep them here or anything. They've got a little more autonomy then a regular pet I guess."

Sensing Adora's restlessness Bow shifts the conversation to changes Adora's made to the house since they helped her move in. t' s all been pretty minimal. There was some furniture that had seen better days and the wallpaper in a couple rooms had been peeling pretty badly so she'd taken care of both.

After a while Glimmer gets up and goes to the restroom, citing the two cocoas she'd managed to put away while they chatted. She comes out shortly after and looks at Adora and the kitten with a furrowed brow.

"Adora, Iknow they're not your pet or whatever , but do you even have a litter box?"

"Oh." Her eyebrows pinch together , mirroring Glimmer's expression. "Idont actually ."

"Ew! Adora!" Glimmer scolds her . "Where do theygo?"

The crease between her eyebrows deepens. "Uhgood question. They go outside pretty regularly, soout there Iguess."

"W ow, pet owner of the year award goes to"…

"Hey! It' s not like they're shitting on my bed. Also, they're not my pet. And they usually like, find some way to tell me what they need, I dont know ."

Glimmer rolls her eyes at this assessment. "Whatever , you might want to think about it before winter is all I'm saying."

"Y eah, okay. You got me there Isuppose."Glimmer nods, satisfied with this answer. The kitten remains asleep on Adora's lap through the exchange and soon the friends decide to take a cue from them. It' s well past midnight by the time the four of them crawl into bed.

That night the kitten migrates from their pillow, to the crook of Adora's legs.

Adora had assumed the kitten would be making themselves scarce while Bow and Glimmer were around, but the reality is quite the opposite. With the exception of an hour or two each day when they scamper out the kitchen door, they're on Adora like white on rice. More than once she has to get after them for tripping her up by winding between her legs, not that they seem to pay her any mind.

Besides all the extra tripping it is nice to have them stick so close. Bow is enamored within a day, even convincing the kitten to let him give them a few chin scratches. Glimmer on the other handwell the two don't exactly jve. They play nice at Adora' s behest, but Glimmer maintains that Adora treats them far too like an "actual person." She has an absolute field day when Adora serves them toast and eggs alongside them at breakfast the first day.

The second to last night her friends are in town they insist on taking her out. "Come on Adora."Glimmer whines over dinner . "There has to be at least *one* bar in this town."

"W ellno. But in the town over ."Adora admits after a full day of wheedling.

"Great!W e can go after we finish dinner. Bow will D"

"*Hey!* "

Glimmer huffs. "Fine, *I* will D happy?"

Bow smiles smugly. "Q ite."

The kitten hops up to Adora's lap, having finished their sammie. Glimmer scoffs. "Seriously Adora, you're not gonna try and bring them with us, are you?"

Adora rolls her eyes at that. "Y eah Glimmer, I totally thought a bar was an appropriate place to bring a cat."

Glimmer raises her eyebrows. "Oh, concerned about propriety now , are we?"

The kitten digs their claws into Adora's thigh, and she scratches their head. They release enough that it doesn't sting anymore but they keep a tight grip on her j eans. "What is with you and this cat Glim?"

"Y eah, Adora has a point." Bow ventures. "Usually you try harder to get cats to like you before you write them off."

"Whatever . This one is weird, it's like they're constantly vibing me."

"A w, but they're so cute!" Bow leans under the table to peek at the kitten now and they meet his gaz e with a firm stare. *"Aren't you little buddy? You're the world's coolest cat, right?"*

They mewl back at him and he sits up with a sq ee. Once they're sure he's no longer looking the kitten relax es into a q iet purr , so soft Adora can't so much hear it as she can feel it vibrating against her leg. She gives them a little noogie and they shrug her off, shaking their head and ears with an indignant sniff.

"Alright, enough about the damn cat. Are you two finished?" They are and so they clean up q ickly from dinner so they can get ready and head out.

The bar closest to Adora is nothing special; the smell of smoke still saturates the air from a time when you could smoke indoors, and it

has soaked into the furniture and walls. There are a couple of pool tables at the far end of a long wooden bar and a jukebox sits in the far corner.

After a couple drinks Bow has a field day queuing up songs. He does it with an enthusiasm that has a few regulars giving him the side eye and fighting smiles. While he gets carried away spending every quarter the three of them could dig up, Adora challenges Glimmer to a game of pool.

"Oh, I think I might actually stand a chance against drunk Adora. Let's do this!" Glimmer gets the balls racked by the time Adora makes it halfway to the table.

"I'm not *drunk*. I had like," Adora ticks off a few fingers, hoping that will help her remember as she counts. It sort of does. "Like, three beers only."

"Uh huh, and when's the last time you had a drink?"

Adora considers that for a moment. "Uhm, okay, you got me there." She shoots off a few commending finger guns in Glimmer's direction.

Glimmer snorts at the drunken kudos. "You dork. Wanna break?"

Adora lines up her shot with surprising accuracy. In the end they play a game that's closer than ever before, but Adora still manages to take the win. Something Glimmer is more than a little pouty about.

They're back at the table, watching Bow make friends with a barfly, when a familiar stranger makes their way over. Adora recognizes them from the grocery store instantly, the same chill runs down her spine and sobers her up more than a little.

"Hello again, *Adora*." Adora squirms under their gaze; first of all because with her seated the stranger towers over her, making their

presence even more domineering. She's also fairly certain they hadn't exchanged names.

"Ohh, hi again. Sorry, um I don't think I caught your name when we met."

"Naturally." They reply rather cryptically. "The name is Shadow."

"Ah, um, that's lovely." Glimmer clears her throat pointedly. "Right, this is my friend Glimmer. She's in town visiting for a while."

"How nice. I'm sure it gets rather *lonely*, in such a small town by yourself. Not many young people." The shrewd look they give her makes Adora feel like she's being studied.

"Yes, well, thank the stars for facetime, right?" She laughs and the sound is foreign and uncomfortable in her ears.

"Of course. Well, I'll leave the two of you as you were. Lovely to see you again, *Adora*."

And awkward silence follows her departure, Adora watches her exit the bar and unconsciously releases tension in her jaw. "Um, new friend of yours Adora?"

She gives Glimmer a look that she hopes conveys; "Are you kidding me?" "No, we met at the grocery store. Just a weird small town character I guess." She thinks about telling Glimmer she'd never given this stranger, *Shadow*, her name but decides against it. After all it's a small town, surely people talk. No reason to worry her friend right before she leaves.

Bow comes back then, saving Adora from any further conversation. He ends up on a rant about how much he loves them, and this bar, and basically just *everything*. It's sweet and it makes Adora sad to see them go day after next. After his rant winds down, Bow insists they stay for the last couple songs he queued up but agrees to go once they play.

Glimmer corrals her giggling, tipsy friends into the car and hops into the driver's seat with a huff. "You two are ridiculous." Her remark just sets off another round of giggling and she chuckles at their inebriation, setting a course for Raz's place.

Back home, she verifies that Adora is capable of getting herself ready for bed and steers Bow toward their room. Adora gets her teeth brushed and heads to her room. When she walks in the door to find the kitten waiting in the middle of the bed, she makes them jump with her squeal.

"*Hey* lil kitten! I missed you." She pouts when her declaration has them inching away. She plops on the edge of the bed and appeals to them. "Aw, c'mon I'm not so bad, am I?"

The kitten doesn't get any closer but stops their retreat.

"See, there ya go!" She offers her knuckles for inspection.

The kitten complies and, well, they're very thorough; sniffing every inch of Adora's hand. A low grumble rises in their chest as they go when they've finished assessing the situation, they begin aggressively scent marking her.

Adora watches on in amusement. "Wow kitty, I promise I wasn't hanging out with any other cats."

She moves to scratch their head, but they pull back with a glare. She puts up a submissive hand and lets them resume their marking until they seem satisfied. When they're through they sit in the same spot and wait to see what Adora does next.

She offers her arms and waits. "Your call lil cat."

They eye her warily and inch closer, still outside the circle of her arms.

f it makes a dif ference,"She of fers. "I dont wanna take you anywhere. I just wanna snuggle you a bit."

That seems to convince them as they continue to get closer, moving slow as if to be sure Adora isnt going to make any sudden moves. After about a minute they make it all the way across the bed and rest their front paws on Adora's stomach.

She scoops them up in her arms and snuggles close, humming contentedly. She rocks them side to side for a few minutes before remembering she's still in her smoky bar clothes. She turns her face to nuzzle it in the kitten' s neck and whispers, "I f I set you down to change can I snuggle you again after?"

She takes the gentle little mewl she gets back as confirmation and sets them on the bed. When she stands, they move to watch her progress from her pillow. Then they allow her to scoop them up again before sliding into bed, curling up against her like a little spoon.

It' s the most peaceful night either has gotten in some time.

Bow and Glimmer take off, returning to their normal lives, and Adora is back to trying for some semblance of routine. There really isnt much to do in this town, and she's taken to playing chess against herself. She mostly feels silly doing it, luckily no one is there to judge her for it. No one that is, except the kitten. They seem to judge her plenty.

After the first game Adora starts to feel more like she's playing against them then herself. Every time she goes to move a black piece the kitten sniffs until, at long last, she ends up making a move that they seem to approve of. The worst part is the kitten seems to be *better* than she is at the stupid game.

After a full weekend of losing to a *dammed cat* Adora decides she's had enough of losing and leaves the game on the shelf. Or tries to at least. The kitten takes to standing in front of the shelf and letting out crying little mewls until she pulls the game down again. She swears they snicker at her grumbling as she sets up another game.

Quickly it becomes their afternoon routine. After lunch Adora makes them each a cup of tea, she long since passed hassling them about their strange tastes, and setting up a game in front of the fire place which she inevitably loses. It's nice, cozy. Adora still feels lonely sometimes but the kitten never seems to let her stew in it for too terribly long.

It's during an afternoon such as this, several weeks after Bow and Glimmer's departure, that an unexpected knock comes at the door. It's curt and firm, just two harsh strikes against the wood. Adora frowns at the kitten. "Are you expecting anyone?"

They sniff and Adora can practically see them rolling their eyes at her.

"Right." She clambers up from her spot next to the coffee table and peers out the front window. It's an especially dark afternoon; rain has been coming down in sheets since the middle of last night. A foreboding sense had filled the pit of Adora's stomach ever since, and it seems to rise with a vengeance with the knock at the door. Through the darkness and the rain all Adora can see is a tall, dark shadow on her doorstep.

She walks to the door and the kitten creeps behind her. Adora opens the door to reveal the stranger from town. Or not such a stranger she supposes, she vaguely remembers their name; Shadow. She's glaring daggers the moment the door opens, but not at Adora; she's staring directly at the kitten. A fierce protectiveness instantly fills Adora's chest and thunder rumbles in the distance.

"Oh, uhm hello Shadow. This is a surprise. Can I help you with something?" Adora fights to keep the combativeness out of her tone.

She doesnt think she succeeds, but she doesnt care much;she *really* does not like the look this strange person is giving her cat.

Lightning strikes a tree in the neighbor's yard and thunder continues to fill the air with sound until it feels like a physical presence. The flash of light illuminates the stranger from behind, casting them in shadow. How apt, Adora ruminates somewhere in the back of her mind. Finally, Shadow's steely gaze trails up to meet Adora's.

"Give me back my cat." Her voice is an eerie calm.

The kitten tightens around Adora's leg and hisses at the stranger.

"I'm sorry you've lost your cat but I'm afraid this isn't them." Adora responds coldly. "I adopted them from a friend whose cat had a litter several months ago, there's no way it could be. This is *my* cat." The lie comes easily.

The kitten shows no signs of relaxing but a purr, whose volume rivals that of the thunder, rumbles from their chest.

When the stranger speaks, they address not Adora, but the kitten. "So, you're a house cat now? How very." She glances around the property with an air of derision. "bucolic. But you will return home to me little one, and when you do I'll make you sorry you ever-"

"It's time for you to go." A strike of lightening hits just inches from Adora's porch, lighting a small patch of grass on fire. The pelting rain extinguishes it, but not before it has the chance to leave a dark burn on the lawn.

The stranger looks up to Adora, their face a cool, collected mask. "You dont know what you're tangled up in girl. You would do well to throw this wretch out, before it's too late."

"Have a nice night." Adora stares the stranger down until they relent and turn to leave. She watches them practically float down the

walkway and out of sight. She closes the door and leans back against it heavily.

Tension slowly drains from the kitten's body, but they keep an eye on the door.

Adora watches them for a moment before stooping down and opening her arms. "C mere?"

Without a moment's hesitation and with a trill they hop up to curl up on her chest and nuz e under her chin. H ving them close, in her arms, a sense of relief slowly spreads through Adora's limbs. She tucks her chin down, over the little kitten, and rides the wave.

They return to the living room like that, content to j st snuggle for a while. A few hours later Adora gets the fire roaring again, having let it burn out in the wake of their unwelcome guest. The thunder and lightning have calmed but the rain continues to pour. She creates a nest of blankets on the couch and curls up with her legs underneath her. The kitten follows suit and lays beside her, watching her curiously.

"I think you owe me an e planation little cat." She tells them seriously, taking a sip from her tea.

The kitten whimpers, sad and small and vulnerable.

"H ey ." Adora scratches their chin lightly until a reluctant purr breaks through. "Y ou're safe here, okay? W ell be okay as long as we have each other. But I would like to know what we're safe from, and I have a feeling you have a way to tell me."

The kitten watches her for a long time. Adora can sense their need for q iet, time to process, and she gives it to them. Sometime later they stand, stretch languidly and walk toward her. They press a paw firmly to her forehead, then moves it down to her chest. When they run off toward her bedroom, she understands it as a silent req est that she stay.

So Adora stays, and she waits. At the bottom of her cup of tea she hears a shuffle behind her. She turns slowly and her eyes widen in shock and mild horror at the sight that greets her. A woman with bronze skin and a dark, wild mane stands before her, dressed in Adora's own clothes. Thunder rumbles outside and lightning strikes in the neighbor's yard. The woman jumps.

"For fuck's-can you chill it out with the theatrics Adora? Gods, I thought you were gonna burn a house down when you hit that tree earlier. Not this house of course, not with all the protections I've got on it, but *still*."

Adora splutters. "Who- *what*-you're in my… *and* in my- and *how*… What do you *mean* theatrics?" is the question she finally manages to get out in its entirety.

The woman rolls her eyes but seems to have softened, grown more tentative, now that the lightening has slowed and the thunder rumbles much further away. "The fire and brimstone bullshit." At Adora's vacant look the woman gestures out the window. "*Hello.*"

Adora looks quizzically back at her. "You want me to…stop the storm?"

The woman narrows her eyes at her. She watches her for a long moment before breaking out laughing. Something about the sound is familiar, a sense of déjà vu fills Adora's chest. "You really don't know? Adora…here, take a deep breath for me." Adora eyes her warily and she laughs again, a bit shorter this time. "Come on, just try it. What's the worst that's gonna happen if you take a deep breath?"

Figuring she has a point Adora does as directed. It does, at the very least, make her feel calmer.

"And another." Adora takes another, and several others as the woman guides her. "Now look outside."

Adora peeks out and stares in shock when she sees it;the storm has ceased. She turns her wondering gaze to the woman who has appeared in her home. "What..."?

"Now , close your eyes."Adora does so instinctively this time. "Okay , think of your happiest memory, the nicest day you've ever had, whatever..Y ou got it"?

Adora's first thought is of Raz, the two of them when Adora was about eight years old, baking in the kitchen not twenty feet away from where Adora sits now. There's nothing especially unique about that day, but something about it sticks vividly in Adora's mind. But then...suddenly her memory shifts. She remembers the walk she went on mere weeks ago;the smell of summer rain in the air , dew on the grass, and turning to see a small kitten watching her.

"I've got it."

"Now look outside again."

It' s...sunny , bright. Dark clouds roll of f into the distance and the sun shines warmly on the land that surrounds them. "I don't"…

The woman laughs again. "How did you never know how *powerful* you are, Adora"?

Adora looks back and studies this stranger in her home. They're petit and angular, practically drowning in a pair of Adora's sweats and an old, forest green henley . Her eyes are...striking and, well Adora' s pretty sure she knows those eyes-even if she doesn't know how it' s possible. But as sure as the sun rises, Adora knows that paired blue and gold gaze, the way it pierces through her is undeniably familiar .

She doesn't feel unsafe at the dawning realization, though maybe she should. "Who are you"?

The woman smiles, small and tentative, her lips quirk to the side and her eyes soften. "Y ou really haven't figured that out either"?

Adora looks to the spot on the blanket still mussed from the kitten's kneading. "Come sit with me?"

She nods and comes to resume her earlier position, and she doesn't have to tell Adora now, but she does anyhow. "I'm a shapeshifter. I can take nearly any form I want but the cat's always been the easiest."

"Hm, what's your name?"

The woman smirks at her then. "What, kitten isn't gonna cut it anymore?" Adora rolls her eyes fondly and the woman's smirk intensifies. "Fine, but I don't want to hear a word of sass from you, got it?"

"Got it."

After a suspicious squint that lasts nearly a full minute the woman simply answers, "Catra."

Adora's lips twitch in an attempt at a laugh. "You're kidding me."

"Hey! What did I just say?"

"Okay but really?"

Catra sniffs, miffed. The action reminds Adora so strongly of the kitten she's spent the last few months with, she has to suppress a giggle. "Yes really! Gods you're a brat."

Adora doesn't really know what to say to that so she just takes Catra in. Catra who's been near living in her house for several months, who's kept her company while her heart mends, who's definitely seen her change more than once.

Adora blushes as all the memories made more intimate by Catra's true nature come flooding back. Suddenly the air is thick and hot with humidity. Catra tips her head and looks on curiously. She looks just a

little too smug for Adora's liking. "Adora? Whatcha thinking about?"

"Nothing! I mean, something, obviously. I'm just, uh, processing, all of all of *this*. So, um, sorry, what's going on exactly?"

Catra huffs out a laugh and smiles at her. "Care to be any more specific?"

Adora frowns. "I don't really know where to start. Who are you? I guess..."

Catra looks at her like she's concerned Adora's lost one too many marbles. "I'm Catra."

Adora's frown deepens and her eyebrows knit together. "Yes, I got the name but who are you? What are you doing here? In this town, in my *house*. You've been practically living with me for months and-and I thought you were a *stray cat*. Granted a *very* self-aware cat, but still! And for the love of Mara, who *is* that awful woman?"

Catra's look of concern has shrunk into a grimace over the course of Adora's line of questioning. "Right all very… *fair* questions. Ah, so… like I said; I'm a shapeshifter. And that woman is my well I suppose you could say she's the closest thing to a mother I've got. Though I think that's giving her *way* too much credit. Anyway, she's a um, a sorceress." Catra tilts her head and looks at Adora, as if trying to gauge her reception of the news.

"Okay." Adora nods encouragingly. Catra looks a little surprised by her easy acceptance, though why she thought 'sorceress' would be harder to digest than 'shapeshifter' is beyond Adora.

Catra nods, still looking a little out of it. "Okay, yeah, so she's not like a good guy? Fuck it, she's evil incarnate actually. So, naturally her ah, business partners' are shady as fuck and she offered them my services on my behalf. When she told me, I told her to fuck off.

Ahem, neither she, nor the goons she basically *sold* me to, were very pleased with that. So, they started um…hunting me."

She says it like a question but it's clearly not. She looks troubled, to put it lightly. Adora scoots closer and moves to put an arm around Catra's shoulders. She hesitates at the last moment, looking into the other woman's eyes. "Is this okay?"

She looks surprised but nods, a little dazed. "Y…ea-yeah, um thanks. Anyway, they'd been hunting me for a few weeks when I…got caught in your storm. Your house was the eye of it, obviously, which is how I ended up on your porch."

"Why did you keep coming back?" Adora's voice is barely a whisper, and she doesn't miss the way the soft words color Catra's cheeks.

"It's…safe." Adora isn't convinced. "I…don't know…, that really is basically it. I…don't understand why I…felt so safe so easily here but…"…

"But?"

Catra groans at the gentle probing and hangs her head until it drops into her hands. "But I've literally never felt safer than I…do in this house. Especially after…do you remember the first time you left me alone here?"

Adora thinks back, she vaguely remembers needing to run errands. "Y…eah, pretty early on, right?"

Catra nods into her hands but looks up before responding, she's worrying her lip when she meets Adora's eyes. "I…shifted back and put every ward and protection I…know on this place. I…wasn't sure I'd come back but in case I…did…. Plus, if they'd tracked me here, even if I'd been long gone, I…had no way to know…," purses her lips and swallows hard before finishing. "…to know what they'd do…to you. T…o find me."

"Oh."

"Also, that's why you were out of salt."

Adora startles. "Sorry, what?"

"Salt. You remember you got home, and you were muttering about how you forgot to get salt?" Adora scowls and tries to remember back that far. "Whatever, I hung around after I left the house and heard you. I was just gonna say that's why, I used it all to help ward the place."

"Oh." Adora's brow furrows. "You use salt for that?"

"Uh, dude. That's like… keeping evil at bay 101."

Adora rolls her eyes. "Ah yes, silly me. That's totally a skillset I have and am familiar with."

Catra snorts. "Right."

They stare at each other a long time, neither knows what to say next. Adora has a million and one questions but at the same time… none of them feel as important as she thinks they maybe ought to. Like; what do this woman's "business partners" want Catra to do that's so terrible? How long is she planning to hide out here, especially now that the sorceress knows where she is? Does Catra know magic? Sounds like she knows magic. So… magic is like, real then?

And still, despite all the questions swimming through her head, what Adora comes out with next is, "So listen, I'm *really* tired."

Catra recoils in surprise, blinking several times quite rapidly. "Oh, okay. That makes sense, I guess." Adora nods. "So, should I go?"

Adora narrows her eyes. "Don't you think she'll be watching the house?" There's no need to clarify who she's talking about.

Catra shrinks into the couch. "I'm fine, I can take care of myself Adora."

"Okay , well Idont think walking into the waiting arms of the person youve been running from for months is exactly taking care of yourself."She pauses, second guessing the firm stance she' s taking on this, but barrels ahead. "I mean, obviously if youre not comfortable,but you should stay ."

"If youre sure?Um, Ican take the spare room?"

Adora should ask her to sleep in the spare room. "Catra, you can sleep wherever you want, okay?"Adora should probably take some space, encourage Catra to *not* sleep in her bed tonight. "I mean, youve been sleeping in my bed for how long now?"Adora really , *really* doesnt want to go back to sleeping aloneto. sleeping without *Catra*. She cocks a single brow and smirks. "Not getting shy on me, are you?"

Adora's bravado seems to strip away Catra's uncertainty as well as it hides her own. "Please, as if Princess. But Imeanif. . *you* are, Ican always shift back to the cat."

Adora scoffs at the teasing. "Sure, whatever youre most comfortable in."

And, *uh oh*, she's definitely stepped in it now if Catra's expression is anything to go by. "W ell, Imean Im *most* comfortable sleeping nude."

Adora chokes on nothing. Catra laughs at her. "Ahem, welllike I said."Catra looks surprised and, if Adora may be so bold as to presume, a little impressed.

"Hm, maybe well work up to that. Think you have a tank top or something Ican borrow?Maybe some boxers?"

They head to the bedroom and Adora manages to dig both up. Catra has to roll the waistband of the boxers several times. In the end they barely cover her ass, but itll have to do. Adora is a flustered mess

when she directs them to the bathroom to brush teeth. She manages to dig up a spare toothbrush for Catra too and they start their routine.

Despite the rather odd circumstances it feels strangely domestic; making eye contact in the mirror with foaming mouths and giggling around their toothbrushes. Adora releases her ponytail and pulls a brush through her hair. When she's through she offers the brush to Catra who considers it for a moment.

"Do it for me?" Her voice is gentle, with a lilt of teasing still at the edges. Adora's cheeks turn from light pink to something deeper and rosy, but she nods in silent agreement. Catra smirks and turns around.

Adora has a good six inches on Catra so there's no need to ask her to sit or stoop down. She starts at the bottom and works her way up Catra's head. By the time she's running the brush over her scalp she's practically purring. It so reminds Adora of the kitten she'd come to love. The implications of that thought paired with Catra's undeniable beauty causes Adora to falter briefly, but if Catra notices she keeps it to herself.

Adora continues brushing long after there are no more tangles to work through, finding the repetitive motion soothing. She's eventually broken out of her reverie by a soft, "Adora?" from Catra.

Adora pulls the brush from her hair. "Hm."

"Sun showers." Adora scrunches her face in confusion as Catra turns to face her. Sensing her lack of understanding Catra inclines her head toward the small window in the bathroom. Sure enough, without obscuring the final rays of the setting sun, a soft rain falls steadily.

"You think it's warm?" Catra shrugs and moves to open the window. Adora joins her and they both stick an arm out. It *is* warm, it's lovely. "This was always my favorite weather when I was younger." Adora shares, pulling her arm back inside.

"Yeah." Catra follows suit and closes the window again, following Adora back into the bedroom as she answers.

"Mm-hmm, Razz my grandma, used to let me wear her big rainboots and jump through the puddles. We'd come inside and have tea and pie. It was always so cozy, this weather always makes me feel so cozy." Adora and Catra climb under the covers, and she doesn't notice the tears dripping down her face at the memories until Catra is wiping them away.

"Sounds nice." Catra's voice is barely more than a whisper.

"Yeah, it was. Ahem. Hey, Catra?"

"Yeah?"

"Can I would it be okay if I held you? Like before, when"…

Catra snorts. "Like when I was a kitten?" Adora bites her lip and nods and Catra smirks back at her. "I'd like that. Just get the light, will you?"

Adora does as she requests and immediately pulls her closer, causing Catra to let out an adorable little squeak. She tells Adora to shut up before she has a chance to comment. So instead she buries her nose in Catra's hair and shakes with silent giggles. From her position she can't see Catra's fond smile, but she can tell the moment she falls asleep. And Adora is right behind her.

Chapter End Notes

Hiii!
So first; this was gonna be a one shot but I'm like two thirds done and it's already gotten like, really, really long. So could be two chapters but honestly might be three at this point. That or the second part will just be super long.
Second; This is like, the third story I started trying to shake off a small bout of writer's block. I still have a pulse on Red Jasper if

anyone who found their way here is reading that, and still have every intention of finishing it! Just lost a bit of steam and needed to step away for a bit.

Anyway, thanks for reading! As always I'm interested and eager to hear any thoughts, but mostly just grateful to anyone who takes the time to read my stories!

In My Home

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The next morning Adora wakes up to the sight of Catra, still lightly dozing on the pillow beside her. She seems to have shifted away in her sleep but Adora, ever the snuggler, drifted right over with her. Her right leg is thrown over Catra's hips and her arm is thrown across her chest, hand tangled in her long hair. She blushes when she realizes just how close she's gotten.

Apparently Catra wakes up sometime in the middle of Adora's debate over whether or not to extricate herself. She looks up when she hears Catra snickering but doesn't miss the faint pink coloring Catra's cheeks. "Well hi there."

"Uh hi! Um, good morning. Did you sleep okay?"

Catra smirks at the bumbling woman still strewn across her body. "Sure, great. Very warm."

She cackles as Adora blushes harder and darts out of the bed. "I'm gonna go make breakfast!" She hesitates rocking from foot to foot, watching Catra roll onto her side to watch her awkward little dance. "Okay, see you out there. Bye!"

Catra's laugh follows her all the way to the kitchen.

After breakfast they get set up with a game of chess. Adora watches Catra consider the board and out of the blue asks, "Is there anything else I should know?" Catra hesitates and despite her effort to cover it, Adora doesn't miss it. "Catra?"

She huffs impatiently. "Listen, it's really not a big deal, but I feel like you're gonna get weird if you find out later."

"Okay"…

t' s my birthday today."Adora' s mouth drops open in surprise. "See, Iknew you were gonna get weird about this!t' s no big deal Adora, really. Idont usually bother to celebrate."

Adora eyes her shrewdly while she fusses with a pawn of Catra's she'd taken early in the game. "Catra by that do youy.ou dont mean you've *never* celebrated, do you"?

"W ell birthday parties werent exactly Shadow W eaver's biggest priority, okay"?Catra snaps, not bothering to meet her eye.

"Catra".Adora feels her heart tear just a little and she walks around the table to crouch by Catra. She's unsure how familiar she's supposed to act but very aware of how she feels when she wraps her arms around her waist. Catra tenses but doesnt tell her of f.

"S fine."She mumbles.

Adora squeezes her once. t' s not, you should get to feel special, like a priority. Id like to try if that' s okay. Nothing major , but if there's a special meal you'd want, and we could make a cake?Or I can make a cake and you can watch."

She feels Catra relax in her arms and some amount of tension leaves her body too. Catra turns in her chair to face her, her hands going to Adora's shoulders;all at once keeping her at a distance and ensuring she doesnt move any further away . "Okay ."

Adora brightens noticeably. "Okay"?

Catra does a poor job of fighting of f a smile. "Y oure an idiot."

Adora beams like the comment makes her feel like the most beautiful woman in the world. "Y eah, Iknow . So, what do you want for dinner?Oh!And what kind of cake"?

Catra blushes under the attention and holds more tightly to Adora's shoulders. "Uhr...remember that mushroom stew you made a while back?"

Adora nods emphatically. "Of course! And cake?"

Catra smiles fondly and shakes her head. "Is it annoying if I make you pick?"

"Not at all!" Then without thinking she leans in to kiss Catra's cheek. When she pulls away, they're both blushing furiously. "So...um, should we get started on the cake?"

"Y-yeah, sounds good." They abandon their game and Catra follows Adora into the kitchen, hopping up onto the counter while she gets to work.

When Adora turns from grabbing eggs out of the fridge she laughs at the site; both familiar and new. "Hey Kitten, you mind scooting over so I can get to the measuring cups?" Catra coughs to hide her reaction to Adora using the familiar term of endearment while she's in her human form. She doesn't move though, and Adora raises an eyebrow, prompting her a second time. "Catra?"

"What? Uh..."

"The drawer." Catra shakes herself back into this reality.

"Right, so what'll you give me if I move?" She inquires, adopting a teasing tone.

Adora blushes at the possible insinuations of that question but scoffs, a bit belatedly. "I mean, it's your birthday. What is it you want?"

Catra's grin grows wicked, she leans in until her lips are right beside Adora's ear. When she speaks, she practically breaths the words. "I wouldn't say no to another kiss." She pulls back, grin still in place,

and taps the spot on her cheek Adora had kissed for the first time not ten minutes ago.

"Yeah?" Catra just nods at the breathless question, so Adora leans in. Catra having *asked* for the kiss this time emboldens Adora, she takes her time. She leans in achingly slow, lingers with her lips pressed against Catra's cheek, and sighs dreamily through her nose as she pulls away. The site that greets her leaves her feeling dazed and smug in equal measure.

"Aha." Catra's widen almost imperceptibly at the sounds that escapes her. She coughs awkwardly and blushes. "Thanks."

"You're very welcome. Now, scoot." Adora waves her to the side and Catra slide her butt over a few inches, watching Adora the whole while.

Adora sets to mixing her dry ingredients, measuring each out carefully, Catra still never taking her eyes off her. She hums while she works, something jazzy and just outside of Catra's memory. The thought that she could get used to moments like these drifts through her mind and makes her freeze. It takes her a while to find her voice but when she does, she can't *not* speak up. Much as she would like to hide from her own thoughts…

"Adora?"

"Hm?" Adora studies the recipe card she pulled from a box an extra moment, eyes squinted so much they're nearly closed, before looking up.

"As much as I appreciate this, I'm confused."

"Oh." Adora frowns and wipes flour from her hands, turning away from her project to give Catra her full attention. "I'm sorry, I mean I didn't-"

"Fuck, no don't apologize to me, I- *please*. It's fine, you're-you're great. Better than great! It's why I'm so it was one thing when you let me stay and treated me well when you thought I was a stray cat. But Adora, this is *weird*, my whole…*situation* is weird! How long are you gonna let me stay?" She holds back the second part of the question; *how long before you kick me out, like you probably should?*

Adora's frown deepens until a crease forms between her eyebrows. "I know it's weird."

She says it so simply, like a confused little kid, Catra can't help but laugh.

"I do! But, I'm sorry, did I miss something, or did you not say that creepy woman and her goons are literally hunting you down?"

"Well, yeah. But that doesn't have to be your problem Adora. For fuck's-I've been *lying* to you! For months I've let you let you take care of me. How are you not at least a little pissed?"

Adora walks closer, until she's standing between Catra's knees. She reaches up and wipes away tears Catra hasn't even realized had fallen. "Catra." She has to blink away more tears at the way Adora says her name; like it breaks her heart, like Catra's name itself is something precious but neglected. "I'm gonna tell you something, because I suspect you've been told something like the opposite.

It's *okay* to let yourself be taken care of. You deserve help when you need it. And I'll ten, I *offered*, and I would have offered the same if you'd knocked on that door like you are now. Maybe not the plain tinned tuna but." She smiles softly, laughter at her own joke threatening the corners of her mouth. "All the rest, yeah. I don't regret letting you stay here, and you can stay as long as you'd like. Although at some point we probably should discuss what to do about *our* little problem. I assume at some point you'll want to be able to leave the house freely."

She smiles encouragingly and Catra allows herself to chuckle wetly. "Gods Adora, you're such a bleeding heart." Adora shrugs, nonplussed. "Thank you, I guess. I feel like I owe you something more than that, I swear I'll find some way to-"

Adora presses her finger against Catra's lips to shut her up. Her eyes widen at the contact, crossing to look at the finger on her mouth. "You don't owe me a thing kitten, consider it a birthday gift if you want." Catra narrows her eyes at her and then Adora is yanking her hand away with a yelp. "Did you just *lick* me?"

Her smile is downright sinister as she responds. "Why Adora? Did you like it when I licked you?"

Adora waves the finger in her face. "You're a big distraction is what you are! I'm *trying* to make a birthday cake over here, if you didn't notice."

Catra's eyes soften and her smile relaxes into something sweeter. "Oh, I definitely noticed." Adora smiles back and ducks her head, blushing. She resumes her baking and her humming after that, and Catra is fully content to laze on the counter and watch. It's familiar and thrilling, and a warm sunny rain falls outside the house the rest of the afternoon.

The next morning Adora wakes up, arms empty, to a gasp from the end of her bed. She whips up, ready to assess the situation, and sees Catra crouched there staring out the window. She must notice Adora moving around because she turns to look at her.

"Oh, good, glad I don't have to wake you up. C'mere, look!" Adora scoots to the end of the bed, still groggy from her sleep, and looks outside. A brilliant rainbow fills the sky, she turns to look at Catra with wide eyes. She's smirking back at her when she asks, "So, have some nice dreams?"

Adora feels her nose scrunch up. "Uh."Catra raises her eyebrows and they pull together slightly. "Wait, you think *I* did that?"

Catra shrugs. "I mean it's pretty gay, seems like you."

Adora laughs right back at her. "Yeah, okay, well I think maybe you're giving me too much credit."Her phone rings then, cutting off whatever protestation Catra was gearing up for. She leans over and when she sees it's Bow calling silences the call.

Catra is staring concernedly at the phone when she turns back. "You're not gonna get that?"

"I'll call him back. I guess I just don't know what to say . My only new piece of news is"…

"Fucking weird, right."Catra snorts, throwing her legs off the bed. She picks up the same sweats and henley she'd stolen from Adora the first night and Adora frowns.

"We should probably get you some of your own clothes."

Catra snorts. "I mean, some underwear would be nice, but I didn't exactly pack my AmEx when I ran. I can figure something out if you don't want me to keep wearing-"

"Shut up, first of all feel free. Second,"Adora stands on her knees and waddles over to Catra's side of the bed until she's kneeling in front of her. She scoops up her hands. "I'm very much aware of your situation, don't make it weird by being a brat about shit, yeah? I'm not exactly loaded but if you haven't noticed I don't exactly have to work right now. And I didn't work for most of my savings, my grandma did all that."

Adora hopes the teasing will lighten things and not alienate this woman. She is after all still something of a stranger, despite the comfort and familiarity between them. Catra seems to war with

herself over it, the corners of her moth twitching. "Whatever Adora, if you're into buying me underpants I won't stop you."

Adora can't suppress an eye roll at that. "You make it sound so salacious."

Catra laughs at that. "Kinda the point Dora, glad you're keeping track. Now if you'll excuse me I'm gonna-"

"Hang on, not those." Adora snatches the old set of clothes from her hands and tosses them in the hamper. She goes to her dresser and pulls out the leggings that are just a touch tight on her, and a tee shirt that she's had since high school. They'll both likely still be a bit big on Catra, but she probably won't swim in them quite as much.

Catra takes the clothes with thanks, and Adora takes the time she's in the bathroom to change herself. She meets Catra in the kitchen where she throws together breakfast. Once they're eating, she decides it's the probably best to broach the subject of what comes next.

"So." Adora begins, Catra sighs heavily in response and looks up from the grapefruit she's coated in sugar. "What do you wanna do I'll ten?"

"Like with the day, or?"..

"Sure but also like, about Shadow and her goons."

Catra snorts out a laugh despite herself. "You make them sound like villains out of an old episode of Scooby-Doo."

"Okay you're not wrong, but still, my point stands."

Catra's laughter peters out and she sighs again. "I don't really know. Before I found you, I was just running until either they caught me or I- or whatever was gonna happen, happened."

Adora thinks she understands where that initial *or* was going, what Catra had resigned herself to. She reaches out and takes Catra's hand in hers. "Can I ask a couple questions?" Catra stiffens but nods, Adora's certain that if she was in her kitten form her tail would be lashing. When the wind rattles the windows, she thinks it may very well be her own tension causing it. "How long had they been tracking you before you ended up here?"

Catra relaxes at that, making Adora think that perhaps Catra was thinking she would be asking something different. "Uh, hard to keep track of time, but I'd guess three weeks or so."

"Do you think they'll just keep looking indefinitely?"

"I… maybe. Depends on what they gave Shadow Weaver for my… services. Also, how many jobs they had planned for me."

"How far do you think they can track you?"

Catra blinks in surprise. "Uh, well Weaver's magic definitely has limits, but Hordak has *resources*. I'm not sure how far that extends but I'd say at least across this continent."

Adora whistles lowly. "Okay, so just up and running probably isn't the best bet, at least not indefinitely."

"Adora." Her tone is warning but Adora ignores it.

"So, the question is, how do we get them to leave you alone?"

Catra scoffs. "Do me in?"

To Catra's surprise Adora doesn't scold her for the morbid joke, rather she looks quite thoughtful. "What if we did?" Catra's mouth drops open. "Just hear me out! We fake it, I'm not sure how exactly, but it can't be *that* hard. Then you could go stay somewhere, I'm sure Bow and Glimmer wouldn't mind unless you have somewhere else you'd rather go. And I've been thinking about selling the house

anyway. I'd wait a little while to avoid suspicion of course but-what? Why are you looking at me like that?"

Catra stands so abruptly it knocks her chair over. "You're crazy! Adora, come on, you barely *know* me. And now you want to help me *fake my death*, sell your *dead grandmother's house*, and what? Run away together? Fuck, don't you have *plans* Adora? Plans that don't involve whatever the fuck you want to call what you're suggesting?"

Adora scoffs and slouches lazily in her seat. "Plans? No Catra, I don't have *plans*. I was working a soul sucking job in a city I hated living in when Razz died. I came out here because it was someplace to just *be* for a minute. Turns out it's kind of a crap place to be without her in the long term. I'm *bored* and without you here I'm lonely too. I don't want to live in the city again, but I'd like to be closer to civilization than… *this*. So, the way I see it, this is just killing two birds with one stone."

She gestures vaguely to the windows and they make a great ruckus as they clatter with a gust of wind. Catra narrows her eyes at the sight. "That's silly. You can do all that without me Adora, without getting any more twisted up in my shit than you are. I'm not sure you understand the severity of the situation."

With that Adora is standing too and thunder rumbles dangerously in the distance. When Adora slams her hands down on the table, hunching over it and leaning toward Catra, their dishes rattle and the thunder claps. "Don't *understand?* Catra, you just told me you were prepared to *die* to get away from these people! Fuck, you were probably getting close to it when you showed up on my doorstep."

Cara glares at that. "I was doing *fine* on my own, I don't *need you* Adora."

Adora laughs, not a trace of humor in the sound. "Fine? *Fine?* Catra, you were starving half to death!" Catra's eyes widen at this revelation and Adora scoffs. "What, you thought I couldn't tell? Fuck, why do you think I let a *cat eat pie*? I mean, yeah; you were kind of a bitch

about it and wouldnt take no for an answer . But *also*, Ifigured anything you'd eat to get some meat on your bones was better than nothing!"

Adora wonders if she's gone too far when she catches sight of Catra's face;she looks every bit the cornered kitten, lost and afraid. All of the fight drains out of her and she falls back into her chair with a huff. t takes a full minute of listening to the faint ticking of the clock from the den for Catra to speak. When she does her voice is small. "What does it matter?

"Excuse me?"Adora is tired, weary , and she knows she sounds it.

Catra takes her seat again too but she's tentative, sitting on the edge of the chair like she might bolt at any second. "I mean, a scrawny little kitten Iget, that' s pretty uncomplicated. But, Adora, Im a person. Im a whole ass person with more than my share of baggage. You dont even know me and, Adora you cantrescue me, it doesnt work that way . And the fact that you're so ready to be totally *fine* with what's been happening here concerns me, for you mostly. "

Adora deflates at this spiel, the wind slows until the windchime in the neighbor's garden can barely be heard anymore. "I'm not trying to *rescue* you, Imm. just trying to help, Catra."She takes a few intentional breaths and Catra avoids her eyes. "I get what you're saying about this being more complicated butis.it really?"At that Catra looks up so sharply that Adora hastens to explain. "I mean, obviously *you* are and-and having a relationship with a person generally is. But the helping you part?Not really .

"As far as what' s been going on, yeah it's super fucking weird and maybe Ihavent really taken time to adjust. t just felt like there were more pressing matters at hand. And Iis it stupid if Isay Idont feel like Idont know you?I mean, Catra we've been living together for months and frankly, you being a person makes *way* more sense than you being a cat. That's an awful lot of personality for such a tiny little body."

Catra snorts but is back to avoiding Adora's eyes. "I dunno, have you met many cats?"

Adora's lips twist to the side in a warped smile. "Okay , fair point. What about all the rest? Where do we stand? I don't wanna make you uncomfortable. I just I care about you, and I want you to be safe as much as I did when I thought you were always a cat."

Catra inhales and the sounds is shaky, Adora thinks she notices about of a quake in her hands as well. "Okay , I think I need a day to think, sleep on it you know?"

Adora doesn't, but she' s always been the act now think later type. "Sure, whatever you need. Um, I guess I'll just get to the dishes then."

Catra nods but doesn't respond, carefully inspecting her cuticles. However , when Adora goes to pass her, through the doorway to the kitchen she stops her. "Adora?"

"Y eah?" Catra doesn't look up when Adora pauses to look at her .

"If I disappeared tomorrow , never to be heard from again what would you do with the house?"

Adora sighs, she wasn't lying when she said she'd been thinking about this a lot. There's nothing here in this town for her, nothing but the house. And a house is not a basis for a *life*, not without some sort of community to exist within it.

"I'm selling it either way . It' s gonna be hard to say goodbye to this last piece of Razz but there are only ghosts here to keep me company. If not for you here to keep me from being all alone, I probably would have packed it in even sooner."

Sensing Catra won't be giving her a reaction, Adora continues onto her task. When she's finished Catra is in the den, set up in the chair. She's absorbed in a book, or at least doing a decent job pretending

to be, so Adora takes the hint and leaves her be. She picks up her own novel and they spend the rest of the morning and into the early afternoon that way.

After a nearly silent lunch Adora busies herself with some deep cleaning tasks, an attempt at relaxation and stress relief. She isn't sure where Catra goes, what she gets up to. She reminds herself more than once that it isn't her business. When she ends up eating dinner alone, she has to remind herself several more times.

Catra walks in the backdoor while Adora is cleaning up. She says nothing beyond letting her know that there are leftovers for her in the fridge, and Catra spares no more than a thank you'. The energy between them isn't tense, but it's far from comfortable.

The only other interaction they have is an hour or so later, while Catra eats alone at the table. Adora had been in the den, debating whether or not it was the time to call her friends, when a thought struck her. She goes to the dining room and drops her phone on the table beside Catra's dish.

Catra looks up, startled at the noise the phone makes on the wooden surface. "I don't know if there's anyone you need to call, anyone you *want* to, but it just occurred to me you haven't had access to a phone for a while. So, if not tonight just let me know if you need it later. I'll leave it here for you now though, just in case."

She doesn't look at Catra when she walks away, and she doesn't see her again for a couple hours. They brush their teeth together, but the mood continues to be distinctly somber. Adora leans over to spit after Catra is through when she mumbles, "I think I'm gonna sleep in the guest room tonight. If that's still okay."

Adora takes her time rinsing her mouth out before standing upright again. "Of course, wherever you're most comfortable." She means it but she can't deny the bitter taste of rejection on her tongue as she speaks.

“Okay thengoodnight.”

Adora makes her best attempt at a smile. “Y eah, goodnight.”

She scoops up the phone Catra had deposited on the counter wordlessly when she walked in and files out of the bathroom after Catra, flipping the light off as she goes. Catra turns to the right without another word and Adora goes in the opposite direction, ignoring the feeling of *wrong* that settles in her stomach. She misses Catra before she even has the door closed behind her.

She knows she ought to not be nosey, but she cant help but look through her phone. f Catra really didnt want her to see, she’d delete any log, right? After all, it is *Adora’s* phone. There are no calls logged but there is one outgoing tex, Adora recognizes the area code of the recipient. t’ s someone from nearby then, this town or one adjacent to it.

‘S. I’m ok, Shfinally pawned me but I’m out for now . Don’t texthis number. Maybe I’ll call soon. W ildcat.’

Adora is relieved to know there’s at least *one* person Catra cared to let know she’s alive. At least one person, besides Adora, who *cares* about Catra. She does her best to center that relief and keep her curiosity at bay, not to mention the small twinge that accompanies it. She just closes her phone and plugs it in by her bedside before crawling under the covers.

t’ s strange, sleeping alone after all this time. She had felt a little silly to be honest, about how comforted she was by the kitten’s presence. Now she wonders if some part of her knew. After all, Catra was never her pet.

The nexmorning when Adora gets up the door to the guestroom is still closed. t’ s still closed when she finishes making her breakfast.

t' s still closed when she finishes eating. And it's still closed when she moves into the kitchen to clean her dishes.

"Y ou should sell the house before Igo missing."Adora shrieks at the surprise of a voice behind her. She turns around to see Catra sitting on the countertop, snickering at her. "W ow, okay, you awake yet?"

"Fuck, you *scared* me."Adora settles a hand over her heart to calm it's racing.

Catra snorts. "Obviously ."

"What were you saying?About the house."

That gets her back in serious mode. "Right, *if* we do this, you should sell the house first, before Igo. Then it wont seem cause and ef fect. t even gives you reason to suspect W eaver has a motive. f she thinks we're about to leave she'd have all the more reason to come after me."

"Okaybut wont she actually come after you?"

"Meh, she knows you have people who'd coming looking for you, so she probably wont try and get to me through you. And I've got so many wards on this place she cant tell if I'm in here even if Istand in front of the window stark naked."

Adora fights down a blush at that image and coughs to hide her reaction. "Y ou've said that before, how does that work?"

Catra blinks in surprise, her legs pausing in their swing against the cabinets. "The wards?"Adora nod. "They're just likerunes.
There's a few drawn at each entry point, doors and windows and stuff, and then a couple more complexones that cover the whole house. Idont know any strong enough to cover the whole property , that's how she was able to get to the door, but the ones Ido know are *solid*. No one would be able to come inside unless you invited them."

"Oh." There's no hiding her blush now and Adora tugs at the neckline of her shirt, suddenly hot under the sun streaming through the window. Catra tilts her head as she watches Adora. "Ahem, anyway, that uhthat makes sense. Selling first."

"There's one more thing though." Adora makes a face to indicate that Catra should continue. "Adorawe dont have to go together. Ido need help leaving and convincing them Im… *gone*, gone. And Im grateful you want to help me, even if Ido think youre an idiot. After that thoughIthink Ihave somewhere Ican go, at least until Iget my feet under me."

Adora should get a better handle on her emotions, she knows that much. At the very least it would be nice if she understood why this declaration makes her want to *cry*. She blinks back her tears, but she can hear the way the threat of them comes through in her voice. "Is that what you want?"

Catra's eyebrows knit together and she looks down to pick at Adora's leggings. t reminds Adora that she should really order her some new clothes, since she cant take her to a store now. "That doesnt matter. Youre the one doing me a favor, one Idont think Ill realistically be able to repay in this lifetime." She looks up to ask, "What do *you* want, Adora?"

"that's not fair! Why does it all have to be on *me*? What you want matters too. Icant make this decision all on my own." Adora finds herself grinding her molars together, she's pretty sure she hasnt done that since the last time she had to take a final exam.

"I just explained it to you!" Catra glares at her, there's no real heat to it and Adora suspects it's borne more from insecurity than anger. "I cant ask you for more Adora! Youre already giving too much, and it's bad enough that Im *letting* you."

Adora sucks her teeth considering this, considering Catra's position. t finally sinks in and she gets what Catra is telling her. "Okay."

Catra's glare doesn't drop but her shoulders fall from where they'd taken up residence by her ears. "So?"

"So, I get why you're trying to not have any more of an agenda, I do. I just still don't know what you want me to say. Maybe you can't ask for more, but I don't feel like I can ask you for *anything*. Not least of all because I don't fully understand what I want, but also we're doing all of this so you can be *free*. That means you have to be free to choose your destiny."

Catra's mouth sets into a hard line. "Fine. Don't ask, just tell me what you want, and I'll tell you if I want the same thing."

Adora turns away to wipe at the few traitorous tears that escape her. When she turns back, she takes a tentative step forward. She's still an arm's length from Catra, but she's close enough to do more than snag her shirt on her fingertips is she *were* to reach out. "I want I… want you to be safe, and I want to know you as someone who is *free* and happy. I want to be around to see that and to know you. I *care* about you Catra. I'm confused about the way I feel within these circumstances, but I know that much at least."

"Okay."

"Okay?"

Catra nods, jaw still set. "Okay, let's do this together."

Adora watches her, waits to make sure she won't instantly take it back, then she nods too. "Good, then I should probably call a realtor today. And I'll need to finish going through the house, decide what to keep and all that." Adora moves to the fridge and pulls out eggs. She goes to the cabinet next for a bowl and sets to breaking the eggs and whisking them while she game plans. "Once it's on the market I say we wait, what, a week? Before I confront Weaver. Then we should probably wait a week or two before you make any moves."

"Adora, what are you doing?" There's a teasing lilt to Catra's voice as she watches Adora pull a pan from the drying rack.

"Uhm... making a plan?"

"No, I mean, didn't you already eat breakfast?"

"Huh?" Adora looks down at the pan in her hands then dumbly back at Catra. "This is for you. Are you not hungry this morning? I just figured."

Suddenly Catra's face is *very* close to Adora's. There's not enough space for so much as a short novel between their noses, but Adora is certain there are enough words hanging in the air between them to fill the pages of one. Catra holds eye contact for an excruciatingly long time. Then slowly, oh so slowly, she leans in to kiss Adora's cheek.

Then she's hopping back on the counter leaving Adora frozen to the spot, completely dazed. "Unnecessary, but you're sweet. Idiot."

Adora shakes her daze off and resumes preparing the eggs. "Uh… right. So, anyway, I'm thinking I can see if Bow and Glimmer can come out for a few days under the guise of helping me clear out the house. Then if you change back to the kitten it should be easy enough for them to smuggle you out. I can finish things up here and then join you and we do whatever we do after that."

"That sounds... smart." Catra watches Adora plate her eggs and throw a couple slices of bread into the toaster.

Adora turns to smile at her. "Yeah? Okay, I know the daughter of the woman my grandma bought this place from still does real estate in the area. I can call her in a little bit here and get that going. The only thing I'm not sure about if how the market *is* around here. It might take a while for this place to sell."

Catra shrugs and accepts her plate from Adora with a kiss to her other cheek. "I wouldn't know."

"Well, we'll reassess when we get there. Maybe I'll drive into town today and get some boxes so I can get to packing up some of the rooms we don't really use. The attic at the very least."

Catra tilts her head and regards her with a calculating look. "When's the last time you like *actually* relaxed?"

Adora snorts, "I'm a very chill person Catra." Catra just raises an eyebrow and tilts her head to the other side. Adora huffs at the look. "Shut up."

The conversation with the real estate agent goes surprisingly well. There aren't a ton of buyers in this area but there's even fewer folks selling. She expects a modest house like Razz's bungalow could get an offer within six to eight weeks. So Adora meets her in person to get the ball rolling and then sets to work on the house.

The attic is mostly mementos and Catra has a blast looking through baby pictures of Adora, much to her chagrin. She even steals one of baby Adora playing with rubber ducks in a frothy bubble bath which she hangs on the fridge. So she can "start each day with a little joy." Adora turns bright red but chooses not to comment.

A week after her initial call with the realtor Adora is standing in the guest room with her hands on her hips. Catra has plopped herself on the bed, which she has continued to sleep in the last week, and sprawled out while she watches her.

"What do you think of the dresser?"

Catra shrugs as best she can in her current position. "It's ugly as sin."

Adora nods seriously. "Okay , yeah, it goes. How' s the bed?"

Catra makes a face Adora doesnt understand. "What? Why?"

Adora pinches her eyebrows together. "Because were deciding what to keep and what to toss. Is that thing worth shipping across the country or would it be better to just buy something new? I replaced the one in the master when I moved in, but this one didnt get as much use so Im not sure how it' s stood up."

"It' s fine." Catra of fers vaguely.

Adora huffs at the lack of clarity and circles the bed to flop down on it. The minute she does she wishes she hadnt; it' s *awful*. The springs poke sharply into her back and calling it lumpy would be a kindness. She's honestly shocked Glimmer hadnt said anything, Bow must have held her back out of a sense of politeness or something.

"Fuck, Catra this thing is a *disaster*. How do you *sleep* on this?"

Catra adopts what Adora has come to recognize as her most stubborn look. "It' s *fine* Adora."

"Okay , well were definitely not keeping it after the house sells and… Catra, I know you've been more comfortable here," She doesnt insert the, *'how I'll never know'* she wants to. Or the *'more comfortable than you are around me, apparently'* she knows she shouldnt even be thinking. "but if you ever want… my bed is plenty big for the both of us. It doesnt have to it' . s not a big deal, to me, if you come back."

Catra clenches her jaw and nods, Adora accepts that' s as much of an answer as she's gonna get for now. Still, that night after Adora has turned down the covers and turned off her light, Catra slips through the door. Wordlessly she climbs under the covers and turns her back to Adora, scooting closer until Adora gets the idea to wrap her arms around her.

Three days later Adora's realtor has told her there's promising interest in the house and they decide it's time. Adora is going into town to plant seeds of doubt around Catra's whereabouts and, ultimately, her survival.

Catra spends the entire morning threatening to come with her, as the kitten. Adora convinces her after no small argument, that even if she doesn't leave the truck it isn't worth the risk. She heads to W eaver's neighborhood and intentionally starts two doors down.

And young mother with a toddler on her hip answers the door. "Hello, can I help you with something?"

"Hi, yeah, I hope so at least. I'm looking for a lost kitten, she answers to Wildcat, or just Kitten." Adora hands her a flyer from the stack she'd printed that morning, her number and a few pictures of Catra as the kitten filling the page.

The woman looks at her with pity. "I'm so sorry hon, we haven't seen anything, but we'll keep an eye out. If you want to leave a stack of those, I can have my son take them to school tomorrow ."

Adora is a terrible actress, but she chances a grateful smile. "W ould you? I'd appreciate that."

"Sure thing, good luck to you." She accepts a few more pages and Adora moves to the next porch for a similar interaction.

Then she's in front of Weaver's door and she summons everything she has in her to pull this off. She knocks harshly and Weaver answers like she's been waiting. "Adora, what a pleas-"

"Save it." She cuts her of f savagely, channeling every drop of genuine rage she has for this woman. She may not have actually taken Catra, but she would if she could. "I know you have her , let her go or I swear I'll make you regret it."

Shadow Weaver smiles indulgently, the expression dripping with condescension. "I have simply no idea to what you are referring."

"You know *exactly* what I'm talking about. How did you get to her anyway? She has the house protected and she wouldn't just *leave*."

"That is exactly where you're wrong my dear." Weaver interrupts in a vicious whisper, leaning in far closer than necessary. "That's what that ungrateful little brat *does*, besides *Adora* isn't that what you were planning to do? I saw your nutty old grandmother's house went up for sale."

Adora can tell Weaver is studying her reaction, knows it's important she maintain control over herself. "That's hardly any of *your* business, but I'll tell you this much; she had no reason to run. Which means you *must* have done something, even indirectly. What, did you tip off your buddies?"

Weaver laughs cruelly. "If you were planning to bring that dead weight with you wherever you're planning to run off to, then you're a fool who got what was coming to you. Now run along, I have more important matters to attend to."

"You awful witch, I will get her back. You won't get away with what you've done." Adora storms down the steps and continues onto the next house, carefully recollecting her composure.

She hits every house on the block and when she gets in the car she finally lets loose. Catra assured her Weaver *would* be watching as long as possible so Adora cries out every bit of her stress. While she's at it she cries for any version of herself that has to watch Catra leave her; by force or by choice. After five to fifteen minutes of that she settles just enough to drive herself home safely to Catra.

Adora's waited too long. She knew she was doing it and then barreled ahead and did so anyway. But now their plan is well into

motion and she needs to give Bow and Glimmer time to make arrangements, if theyll even agree to help.

Catra had given her just about the most judge mental look she could muster up when she found out Adora never told them. When Adora had whined about how hard it is to find the words to tell them she had no pity to spare. "Yeah well, Imanaged, and so can you."

Adora complained that at least Catra had herself as a visual aid but that hadnt seemed to help her case. So now Catra is beside her on standby, ready to join her on the video chat when the time comes, and Adora calls her two best friends in the world.

Bow picks up almost immediately, grinning wide at the sight of Adora. "Hey friend!"

"Hey Bow!" Adora's attempt at chill is laughable at best. "Um, is Glimmer there with you?"

"Im here, just finishing with the dishwasher." Glimmer calls from offscreen.

"Oh, cool uhcan you join us when you have a sec? Umlhave some news and Imight need a favor."

"Of course Adora, you know well help you however we can." Bow offers preemptively.

"Wellwhy dont you wait until Itell you what the favor is." Adora bites her lip and glances at Catra from the corner of her eye. Catra has her own lip between her teeth and looks beyond nervous. Adora squeezes her hand in reassurance and doesnt let go.

Glimmer walks on screen then and drops down onto the couch beside Bow. She scoffs, "Please, were always here for you. What do you need?"

"Well uh" Adora glance over to Catra again. "You know the cat?"

Both of her friends look confused, but Bow looks much more enthused at the topic than Glimmer. "That *monster*? Yeah, we remember."

"Glimmer!" Bow admonishes, slapping lightly at her arm.

Adora glances at Catra again, she's an absolute wreck at Glimmer's words. "Uh, yeah, about that. You know how they were, uh, kind of special?"

Glimmer narrows her eyes, but Bow responds before she has a chance. "Totally! Big personality on that one, but such a secret softy."

That lightens Catra up enough for an awkward scoff. "What was that?" Glimmer demands at the sounds. "Is someone there with you? You keep looking off screen all cagey like."

"I do not!"

"Well." Bow's hesitant whine is enough of a confirmation that; yeah, Adora totally is doing that.

"Fine, no, I'm not alone. There's someone I want you to meet."

"Oh my gosh, Adora! Did you find an available lesbian out there in the boonies?" Glimmer gasps, leaning in eagerly.

"Aw, does she like your cat?" Bow coos, then gasps as a second thought hits him. "Oh no! Does she hate them? Is that the favor you need; she hates them so you want us to take care of them so your beautiful queer love can flourish?"

"Bow!" Adora cuts him off before he can really get going. "No, that's not it at all. Listen, just keep an open mind. Um." She looks over to Catra a final time, now to beckon her over with a tilt of her head. "Guys, this is Catra. Catra, um well *you know Glimmer and Bow*." Adora hopes that's enough for them to get the picture.

"Wow! Adora I was kind of kidding when I asked if you managed to find someone out there."

"*So* nice to meet you." Bow waves eagerly . So, not enough of a clue then.

Catra looks over to Adora, clearly indicating that she gets to field this one. "Uh, yeah, so you guys already met."

"Oh, sorry ." Bow pulls a face. "Was that at that bar? I got a *little* tipsy."

Glimmer frowns. "No, I was totally sober , and I don't remember this."

Adora groans and Catra steps in, attempting to help. "Yeah, ahem, you guys might not *recognize* me. I look, like a bit *different*." At their blank looks she groans too, and that's all it takes for her patience to run out. "Fucking stars above guys, I'm the cat, the cat is me. *Are you getting this?* "

"Uhh." Bow's eyes are wide as saucers and he seems to have lost all ability to speak.

"Adora what is this crazy lady talking about? Who is this?"

She clears her throat awkwardly before she answers. "This is Catra, and uh, yeah. She's a shapeshifter so last time y'all met she was… a…*cat*."

"I'm sorry ." Glimmer starts, and air of carefully controlled emotion in her tone. "Are you trying to tell me that you're dating your cat?"

"We're not dating!" Adora ignores the snif f Catra responds to that with, but she's more than a little curious about where it's coming from.

"Oh, well what a relief. So, you're just living together? Don't you let her sleep in your bed?" Glimmer glares into the camera.

"Well, yes." She chooses to withhold the fact that Catra sleeping in her bed isn't a past tense scenario at this point. "But there are extenuating circumstances!"

"Oh, I'm sure." Glimmer's eyes could not possibly roll any harder. "I cannot *wait* to hear this."

"Well so there's this like, witch?" She looks to Catra for guidance and her look of derision could rival Glimmer's. For her part Glimmer just laughs, clearly disgruntled.

"Wow, you're really bad at this, no wonder you put this off."

"Excuse me?" Glimmer interrupts Catra. "*How long* did she put this off exactly?"

Catra shrugs nonchalantly, like she couldn't give a crap less about throwing Adora under the bus. "Like ten days. Also, there's no *witch*. My mom is into some nasty shit, some of that shit includes dark magic, and she kind of, um." Here Catra falters so Adora decides it's probably her turn to help out.

"She offered some criminals Catra's assistance. There may or may not have been an exchange for those services."

Bow finally finds his voice and in a terrified whisper asks, "She's sold you?"

"Well, *maybe*." Adora offers but Catra just scoffs.

"Almost definitely."

"Okay, okay, that's really fucked up and all, and like, sorry your mom is a bitch-"

"I forgive you." Catra jokes dryly. Glimmer does *not* appear to think that's funny.

"but Im still not totally buying the Catra used to be the cat' bit. I mean, Adora have you *seen* this?"

"Basically , yeah."

"Basically?"

"W ell like, she went into the other room but-"

"And you just *bought* that? Adora-"

"Y eah, Glitter-"

"t' s *Glimmer*."

"Gesundheit. The only reason Ididnt change in front of Adora is because the fur doesnt exactly shift into *clothes* if you catch my drift."

"Convenient. And why cant you shift into the cat in front of her?"

Adora bites her lip, she hadnt asked because she *knew*. Also, it had seemed impolite. But shed be lying if she said she wasnt curious about how it works. Catra sighs heavily. "I can. And Iwill if Ireally need to it's just pr.etty painful."

Glimmer just harrumphs, likely perceiving that as another handy excuse. Adora figures it' s probably time to intervene and move them onto the nexpart. "Listen, this is really only-"

"No, she' s supposedly been living in your house for *months*, Ithink you deserve to know if it's true, or if youre just being taken for a ride."

"Glimmer! Ido know , okay?" Catra stops her from going further with a hand on her wrist.

"She kind of has a point Adora." She murmurs, loud enough that Bow and Glimmer should be able to hear but quiet enough that it' s

obvious she's only talking to Adora.

"I don't need you to."

"And I appreciate that, but I think your friends deserve some peace of mind too, don't you?" She turns to face Bow and Glimmer while Adora chews on that. "Listen, maybe we can compromise? The ears and the tail are frankly the easiest part. That enough to convince you?"

Bow, for some inexplicable reason, gets heart eyes at this. "You can have kitty ears? Why don't you do that *all the time?*"

Catra levels him with a look. "I think that should be fairly obvious. Look, just shut up and give me a second okay?"

Glimmer nods and that seems to be enough to speak for everyone's agreement. Catra closes her eyes and takes a deep breath. The transition is surprisingly quick and smooth. Adora feels something soft, a long tail, brush against the back of her arm. She looks over to Catra and her human ears are gone, replaced by something distinctly cat like.

She pins her ears back, seemingly by instinct, and her tail wraps around Adora's upper arm. Adora frankly can't explain why this does it for her, but she's never been more certain of her desire to kiss Catra. Maybe it's the recall to the way they spent their time together at the beginning or maybe it's that Catra was so willing to put herself on display like this just to make Adora's friends feel better, to do so *for Adora*. Either way she's ready for this call to end *now*.

Bow and Glimmer look gob smacked to say the least. Even Glimmer seems to be left speechless for once. "Okay, so now that's all settled can we get to the reason we called?"

That snaps Glimmer out of it, Bow not so much. "You mean this isn't *it*? Adora, your girlfriend is a cat sometimes and you're telling me there's *more*?"

"Well first of all, she's not my girlfriend. And secondly, yeah pretty much. So, like we said Catra's mom is shady and so are the people she works with. The reason Catra started staying here is because she was hiding from them and I, obviously, thought she was just a cat in need of a decent meal."

Bow laughs at that. "Oh man, all the people food makes so much sense now!"

Surprisingly Catra laughs too and her ears spring up. "Yeah, she gave me tuna from the can the first night. It was." She shivers dramatically. "Not good." She turns to Adora and her tail tightens around her arm. "Not that I didn't appreciate it!"

Adora smiles gently at her. "I know." She turns back to her friends on her computer screen. "So, Catra needs to get out of dodge and um, I'm selling the house."

"*What?*" Adora winces at Glimmer's thundering and the air in the room grows icy, condensation gathering on the windows as the temperature outside drops even further. "You're selling your *house* for this person?"

"No! No, you didn't want me out here all alone *anyway* Glimmer, remember? And you were right." Glimmer seems mostly mollified by that statement and the goosebumps that had risen on her and Catra's arms disappear. "It's boring and lonely and there's nothing to do here. So, I put it up for sale and the realtor said there's already some interest."

"Okay and are you coming home?" Adora hears Glimmer's unasked question; *And are you brining her with you?*

"Temporarily. You know I never vibed with the city, but I also hate being so far from you guys." Both of her friends seem to soften at this. "I figured I could come back, reset and maybe buy some land outside of the city."

"Okay , fine. Ido like that idea. So, what' s this favor you need?"

"Right, so once the house sells, Im hoping you two will come under the guise of helping me clear out the house. And when you go Catra will shift and you can smuggle the kitten home with you. She can stay with you or she might have someone else in the city she can stay with. Then once Ihand of f the keys to the new owner, Ill be right behind you guys."

"Idont know Adora"…

She expected hesitation from Glimmer , but when Bow starts nodding along, she loses a little bit of hope. "Y eahIdont like the part where you stay by yourself. f there are a bunch of goons watching your house, it doesnt seem wise. What if Itake Catra home and you and Glimmer come back together?ust to be sure."

All three women react with surprise to this suggestion. Catra is the first to speak, her ears flickering intermittently. "t' s not a bad idea… the wards should hold for a while, but by the time Im a few hundred miles away theyll get weaker . And Ill need to let them expire so the new owners can come and go freely."

Adora chews her lip nervously and turns to look at Glimmer. She huffs dramatically and her assent comes out as a groan. "*Fine*, we're here for you, whatever you need. But Im still not sure Ilike this."

"Ill take it!" Adora announces. After that there' s not much to talk about, logistics will need to be worked out once Adora actually has a timeline for them. She makes excuses, which Bow and Glimmer seem eager to take, and ends the call with promises to be in touch soon.

The moment the call has ended she's sagging against Catra with a sigh. She's content to let herself melt into a pile of goo right there until something brushes her arm. Catra's tail, Catra still has her tail and ears out. Adora sits up, ever so slowly. She wants to look, to ask

about it, but she isn't sure what constitutes good manners in this situation.

Her internal struggle must play out on her face or something because suddenly Catra's tail lands in her lap, right over where her hands lay. She looks up to Catra, surprised to see her watching her face. She rolls her eyes when she sees Adora looking.

"It's fine, you can touch it. It's sensitive though so just be gentle."

Adora nods solemnly and pets her tail reverently. After a minute or so of gentle strokes Catra lets out a sigh like a purr. Terrified to shatter the moment, Adora whispers, "Hey Kitten?"

Catra squints her eyes open, the only indication she's heard her.

"Can I?" Adora leaves her left hand where it is and her right stretches tentatively toward Catra.

Her eyes stay held in narrow slits but after a couple moments the creases at the corners soften. Catra nods.

Adora closes the remaining distance and scratches behind her ear. She had wondered if Catra would like the same touches now that she did as a full-on kitten. Turns out;she absolutely does. Or at least, the way she pushes into Adora's hand with her eyes shut indicates as much.

Of course, Catra is *not* a kitten. She is a fully grown, absolutely gorgeous, human person and the intimacy of the moment does not escape Adora's notice. She imagines how Catra might react if she used the hand she has on the side of Catra's head to pull her in close, close enough to kiss her. But Adora wont do that without permission, and she's too afraid to ask.

Eventually Catra starts to droop with exhaustion. She allows Adora to lead her into the bathroom, through their nightly routine, and into bed. When they wake up in the morning their legs are an

indistinguishable tangle, and their faces are close. Adora is still too afraid to ask.

A month of confusing domesticity later and the house sells, just a smidge below Adora's asking price. The house is almost entirely packed up now. Furniture with sentimental value and a few larger boxes are being shipped to be put in storage in Brightmoon on Monday, and Bow is taking a few smaller boxes home with him. El and Glimmer are set to arrive the following afternoon.

To keep up the façade Adora has continued to "search" for Catra. She's even gone so far as to camp out in front of Weaver's place from time to time. They're ready, they can do this. The last preparation Catra had suggested were a few alterations to her appearance. So now Adora stands behind her in the bathroom with a pair of kitchen shears in hand.

"Are you *sure* you don't want to wait and go to a professional when you get to the city?"

"What? No, Adora I'm not gonna pay some idiot to do something I'm capable of doing myself." She catches Adora's eye in the mirror and raises a single brow in challenge. "And if you're too chicken shit to do it, *I will*."

Adora sets her jaw stubbornly, she wants to be able to rise above Catra's goading but that doesn't seem to be in the cards. "Shut up, I can do it. I just don't want to hear you complaining about an amateur job."

"Fine. I'll find something else to complain about."

"Brat." Adora murmurs under hear breath, much to Catra's amusement. She can't fight the smile that surfaces along with the comment, which she's certain undermines the sentiment.

She steels herself with a deep breath, puffing out her cheeks and blowing it out hard enough to ruffle Catra's hair. Then she starts. She begins pretty conservatively, working her way shorter and shorter as Catra's long, dark curls fall to her bathroom floor. Catra just sits patiently, watching her with interest. The unrelenting look makes her nervous so she does her best to ignore it.

When she's finished Catra is left with a cute pixie cut. Adora was worried she'd make Catra look silly, but she should have known better. She wonders if there's any way she *could* make Catra look bad and decides; no, probably not. She blushes at the thought but luckily Catra is too distracted by her new cut to notice, busy checking herself out in the mirror.

After a thorough inspection she turns around. "Damn Dora, I really didn't think you had it in you, but- fuck are you *crying*? It looks fine dude, unless you did something weird to the back" her face scrunches and she goes to feel the back of her head.

Adora *is* crying, but the haircut is really only adjacently relevant. With Catra's hair spread on the ground around them the reality of their future has hit her full force. "No, no it's not that." Adora sniffs and rubs her face in agitation.

"Okay." Catra still looks concerned, standing from the stool she's been perched on to grab Adora's arm. "So, what's going on?"

"It's silly really, I'm just I'm so *scared*" Catra. What if it doesn't work? What if something *happens*?" She doesn't add, *to you*, though truthfully it feels like the most important part.

"It's *fine* Adora, we're gonna be okay." Catra squeezes her upper arm a little tighter and moves just a touch closer. When Adora bites her lip, a clear sign that she's not convinced, Catra suggests, "Hey, why don't we go hang on the bed?"

The couch, and most of the den furniture, is gone as of yesterday. Everything Adora wasn't keeping had either been sold or hauled to

the dump. It hadn't exactly left them many places to lounge. With that in mind Adora follows Catra to the bedroom, and when she hops on the bed first and opens her arms Adora doesn't hesitate to crawl into the embrace.

"What are you so scared of, huh?" Catra asks, as if she can't guess.

Adora sniffs again and cuddles in closer. "I don't want to lose you." *I don't even really have you* ;she thinks to herself.

Catra breathes in sharply and Adora feels her press a kiss to the top of her head. "You won't." She whispers there.

"I don't think you can promise me that Catra."

"You *won't* Adora." Still unconvinced Adora cries in earnest. Catra sighs, "Oh, Adora." She holds Adora, gently rocking her from side to side, until she calms. With Adora's head still tucked under her chin, she starts speaking again, more tentative now. "Adora, I think we should talk."

Adora stiffens;no good conversations have ever started with those words, have they? She suddenly registers rain pattering insistently against the bedroom window. Still, she doesn't move from the haven of Catra's arms. "Okay?"

"About what happens once we're both in Brightmoon."

"Okay ."

Catra huffs at receiving the one word answer for the second time. "Adora, come on."

"Come on what?" Adora pulls back at last, face set in a scowl, to look Catra in the eye. Catra is scowling right back at her.

"Somehow , we haven't talked about this yet and, I don't know , what are your plans?

Adora snorts. "I thought we established I don't *have* any plans. I was just gonna wing it."

"Unbelievable." It doesn't sound like a compliment. "Okay, so how long are you planning on staying in the city? Are you still planning on getting another house out there?"

"Uh, yeah, the first possible moment I can leave honestly."

Catra's jaw clenches. "Great."

Adora purses her lips in a mixture of concern and confusion. "Okay, does that not work for you?"

Catra laughs and the sounds is harsh and grating. "For me? Am I coming?"

Adora sucks in a hard breath. "Was that not the plan? I was under the impression we were in this together."

Catra growls and the crease between Adora's eyebrows deepens. "Adora, what the fuck *is* this? This situation is confusing enough as it is and you're really not helping things! You want us to, what? Move out to the country together? Then what? Just live out there together indefinitely? You do realize what that sounds like, don't you?"

"Uh, no?"

"For fuck's- it sounds like fucking cottage core, lesbian life partners Adora! You don't pack up and move to the country to live happily ever after with a *roommate*. Not to mention the fact that I don't have the faintest idea what you expect us to do for *work* out in the middle of who knows where."

"Oh, are you not a lesbian?"

Catra looks positively dumbstruck by the question. "*That* was your takeaway?"

"Uhno?"

Catra laughs, just full on, out of place *laughter*. "You're hopeless! So what if I *am* a lesbian? We aren't together Adora, don't you get it? That's what so confusing about this whole thing! You want to make life plans together like we are, but we *aren't*."

"Oh are you asking if I want to be?" Catra's nostrils flare but she gives no other response. "Do you want to be?" Still nothing more than a harsh glare. "Because I'm confused Catra but, I *do* want to factor you into all my future plans, and I *don't* want to know what it's like to live without you. I don't want to have to remember what it's like to fall asleep without you beside me."

Catra rolls her eyes. "Be *more* vague Adora, please."

Adora gulps. She's not sure if that's fair, she feels like that was far from vague. She'll admit though, it definitely wasn't explicit. "I wanna be with you Catra, I do."

Catra sighs, still seemingly unsatisfied. She rubs a hand over her forehead, massaging it briefly with the heel of her hand before dropping it. "Okay I really need you to be as clear as possible here Adora. Do you want to be with me like you like living together platonically? Or do you wanna be with me like-"

"Catra." Adora feels her eyes tighten, her lips settling into a frown. "I just told you I want to fall asleep beside you every night for the rest of my life. Does that really sound platonic to you?"

Catra's hands fly into the air in exasperation. "With anyone else? No, fuck no. But Adora, we've been doing that for *months* now."

"Oh I thought"…

"*What?* What *exactly*, in as much excruciating detail as you can manage, did you think?"

I thought my feelings for you aren't really platonic Catra. I just… figured it made sense to wait and sort all this out," She waves a hand between the two of them. "until after," She gestures vaguely to the air around them. "this was all sorted, after we'd gotten out. You didn't say anything either, so I thought either you were on the same page or you just…don't feel the same. I've been pretty worried you just don't feel the same to be honest. But either way, in the middle of trying to escape an evil sorceress didn't exactly feel like the most romantic time to put the moves on."

Catra blinks and Adora can practically see the gears in her brain whirring. "Oh." A few more blinks and she seems to catch up, head tilting to the side and smirking at Adora now. "You have moves?"

Adora snorts and lets the mood lighten. "Please, I'm so smooth."

Catra cocks an eyebrow and scoots closer. "Oh yeah?"

Adora chokes on air when Catra's breath brushes across her face. "Ye-yeah."

Catra leans in, even closer now. "Prove it."

Adora gulps, it does nothing to help her dry throat. "Are you asking me to kiss you?"

Catra tips her head back and laughs. Looking at Adora again she murmurs, "I mean, I wouldn't compla-"

Adora doesn't even let her get the full sentence out before she's gently cupping the back of her neck and pulling her close. The kiss is soft and chaste, but unendingly tender. Adora's heart feel like a little baby horse; just trying to get it's legs under itself, tripping along in her chest, ready to begin a new life.

She gives a dreamy sigh when Catra's hand comes up to cup her face and gently stroke her cheek. Their free hands find each other and their fingers interlace. Adora feels a smile pressed against her

lips as Catra lets out a breath like a giggle. With one last squeeze of her hand, she pulls back. The sun shines warmly through the window.

"Wow."

Catra snorts and rolls her eyes. "You're an idiot."

"Yeah, I know." Adora smiles dopily at Catra, who smirks fondly back. Finally, when she can bear the silence no longer Adora prompts, "So…cottage core lesbian life partners, huh?"

Adora's heart sinks when this has the opposite of the desired affect; Catra's expression droops and she pulls back slightly. "Yeah…Adora, I…I still don't know about this plan."

Adora is big enough to admit she pouts a bit at this. "What part exactly?"

Catra winces, like Adora's just said something harsh rather than asked a simple question. "Look, I know our situation is, well… unique to say the least, but if we weren't romantically involved it's fucking weird at best. If we are…don't you think moving to a whole new place and out to the country together is a little fast?"

Adora considers this. She's been so focused on executing the plan she hasn't really taken time to think about stuff like that. Now that Catra mentions it though… "A little, I guess."

Catra snorts at her. "A little? Come on Dor."

"Fine, yes;it's super weird, but also, we've been living together for months, right?"

"Right…" Adora can still sense Catra's unease and she sighs. Catra has a point;Adora has a tendency to decide on a path and barrel ahead with it. And, given the circumstances, she feels intensely protective over Catra;she'd do just about anything to make sure she

was safe. So…perhaps Catra had a point about Adora trying to rescue her also. Just a little one though;Adora knows Catra is her own person, really.

"What do you want Catra? What makes sense for you?"

Catra looks suddenly very small at the question. "I just…I don't like feeling dependent on you. I'm really, really grateful to you for helping me out of this situation but…"

"But you don't want to be reliant on me forever. So, if I buy a house in the country where you feel like you don't have options to work…" Catra nods in affirmation. "Okay…what if we take a year?"

"A year?" Catra scrunches her face up, bewildered.

"Yeah," Adora answers, gathering steam as a plan forms in her mind. "I lived in Brightmoon for six years, I can handle one more. We'll both do our thing, and you can figure out what you want your future to look like, then at the end of the year we revisit getting a place outside of the city. If that's what you want." Adora bites her lip, feeling shy as butterflies rise from the depths of her stomach. "And in the meantime...we date?"

Catra's mouth opens and closes of its own accord a couple times before something else settles into her expression and she smirks. "You wanna date me?"

Adora rolls her eyes with a scoff. "Gee, sorry, did I not make that clear enough for you?"

Catra shrugs, her smirk never slipping. "Guess not."

Adora gives her a shrewd look, studying that infuriating, flustering smirk. "Are just trying to get me to kiss you again?"

A laugh. "You know I was, but silly me, seems I need to take matters into my own hands."

And with that she pounces, kissing Adora until her back is flat on the mattress and keeping her there until they're both too drowsy to kiss properly anymore.

They keep each other up into the wee hours of the morning, so they're just finishing a late breakfast when Bow and Glimmer arrive on their doorstep the following afternoon. Adora ushers them inside and they spend the afternoon and evening catching up. It isn't a late night; Bow is short on time off, so his turnaround time is tight. He and Catra will be leaving first thing in the morning.

She and Catra give their guests the bed and cuddle up on a pile of blankets in the spare room. The mood in the room is quiet, somber in the face of tomorrow. They don't talk much, not at all really. Adora just cradles Catra's face in her hands, brushing her cheeks softly with her thumbs and stroking her fingertips over every inch. She doesn't say it out loud but she's sure Catra knows; she's memorizing it, every inch, just in case.

At some point she moves one of her hands from Catra's face to comb through her hair. It quickly lulls her to sleep but Adora stays awake most of the night, soaking up every moment of Catra's presence that she can. Just in case.

Chapter End Notes

First of all thank you so much to everyone who left comments and kudos on the first part of this story! I'm beyond flattered at the response!
Second, I'm gonna be honest here and say I have exactly *no* self control when it comes to chapter/word count (if you read You Make Me See Stars you know, that bish was supposed to be a one shot, then 10-12 chapters and ended at like 22 lol) So this guy is definitely gonna be three at least but there is a possibility of a fourth chapter that would theoretically be more of an epilogue vibe, but we'll see! I'm working on the third part

now!
Also, I didn't post it in the last chapter but try to include it in notes on my stories at least once, I'm over on twitter @logoblens, and always looking for that good gay and/or SPOP content so feel free to come find me there!

And to round this out, as always I appreciate the time folks take to read my stories so much, So *Thank You!!* And I always double appreciate those who take time to share their thoughts! Anyway, see ya next time :)

To My City

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The car is loaded, the wind howls and rattles the windows of Raz's old house. Bow has said his goodbyes to Adora and Glimmer, everything is ready. Still, Adora can't seem to let go of Catra's hands.

They're in the kitchen;Catra perched on the counter with Adora stood in front of her, their hands held in her lap. Bow and Glimmer had stepped out to give them a moment ten minutes ago. They've said very little, haven't so much as whispered a 'goodbye'. Mostly they're just staring.

Catra tips forward and leans her forehead on Adora's. "Hey dummy, I'm gonna see you in a week, right?"

Adora's breath shudders in the inhale. "Right, of course. Not even, six days."

That earns her an encouraging smile. "Even better, six days. You can call Bow if you need to talk to me, but you're gonna be fine."

"Right, and you too."Adora enforces sternly. Catra chuckles at her tone.

"And me too."She sighs and closes her eyes, Adora watches her, refusing to give up so much as a moment of studying her face. Her eyes blink back open and she looks unsurprised to see Adora watching her. "Adora, I-"

"Hm?"

"You're amazing, you know that?"

"Shut up." Adora mumbles.

Catra doesn't so much as crack a grin, shaking her head. "I mean it. You-stars Adora- you took me in as this scraggly ass kitten and treated me like a fucking person-"

"You *are* a person."

Catra rolls her eyes and give her a stern look. "Which you didn't know at the time. You nursed me back to health, accepted me without question when you found out the truth, and turned your whole world upside down to help me. I don't even know how to begin to *understand* that level of kindness, let alone repay it."

Adora is blushing fiercely by this point, hardly able to hold Catra's eyes. "Ahem, well I mean I don't expect you to-"

"I know you don't Adora, that just compounds it, you know?" Catra's tone is so, so soft. Adora doesn't know what to do with it. The howling wind calms ever so slightly.

"Um, not that I don't appreciate it but why are you what are you getting at?"

"I love you." Catra pushes the words out so fast they nearly jumble together, but Adora hears them loud and clear. She gasps at the confession, her eyes as wide as saucers. The neighbor's windchime lets out a playful tune. Catra hurries on. "Listen, normally I wouldn't you know, so soon. I just, who knows what the next week is gonna bring? And I really do Adora, how could I not?"

"Catra"…

Catra's smile is tenderness and love and just a hint of melancholy. "I had so much more time with you as you, you know? And you spent every minute of that time taking care of me and making me fall in love with you. So, don't say it back. I didn't tell you to hear it back, I told you because I'm sure and I want you to know. Okay?"

Adora blinks her eyes, freeing a couple stray tears. Her voice is just a whisper when she responds. "What if I know too, what if I mean it?"

Every bit of emotion in Catra's expression intensifies at that. "Do you?" She sounds fairly certain she knows the answer, Adora gives it anyway.

"I think I do."

Catra closes her eyes and pulls her head from where it still rests on Adora's. She uses her hand, cupped behind Adora's ear, to guide her head down so she can kiss her forehead. When she's caught Adora's gaze again her smile is still in place, as genuine and feeling as ever, but tears threaten at the corners of her eyes.

"Tell me when you know for sure, okay?"

Adora nods emphatically and Catra chuckles, pulling her in for a tight hug. Their faces nuzzle into each other's necks and Adora sighs heavily. "I care about you, so much."

Catra nods into the tight spot she's fit her face into. "I know." She sighs heavily and waits a moment more before saying, "I should go soon."

Adora shakes her head. "I don't want you to."

"It's still time."

Adora sighs and pulls back. Wordlessly she takes Catra's hand again and squeezes before walking into the den to find her friends. Bow looks up from Glimmer, leading her to turn and look at them. The pity in both their expressions just about kills Adora.

"About ready?" Bow questions.

Catra nods and Adora speaks up. "Yeah, just about. Just remember; I have my red backpack packed with snacks and a change of clothes, so just remember to leave it with her when she changes

back. And *don't* address or acknowledge her until you're *at least* halfway, just in case someone follows you. Oh! And I packed a box of salt in there, for when you get to Brightmoon; in case you and Glimm forgot to get one. And-"

Catra stops her with a hand and her shoulder. "He's got it babe, we've got this."

Adora sighs with her eyes squeezed shut and looks down to Catra. "I know, I know . . . just keep each other safe, yeah?"

"Of course." Catra stand on her toes to kiss Adora's cheek then slips away to change.

"It's really gonna be okay Adora, I've got a good feeling." Bow attempts to assure her.

She nods, though it does precisely nothing to ease her anxiety. The wind picks up and the wind chime's song turns into something chaotic. "Right, of course. I'm worried about you too though Bow. Be careful, okay?"

He smiles reassuringly at her. "I will Adora."

They're interrupted by a chirruping meow coming from the doorway as Catra trots up to Adora. She smiles and leans down to scoop her up, holding her close to her chest. "Hey, long time no see, Kitten." She teases.

Glimmer fakes retching noises from beside her. "This is the weirdest flirting I have ever seen."

Adora rolls her eyes and nuzzles into Catra's fur. "Shut up Glim, you're just jealous your boyfriend is always a human."

Catra purrs loudly at the teasing but Glimmer just scoffs. "As if."

Very genuinely Bow adds, "Honestly? I *am* really jealous, I wanna be a cute kitty whenever I want!"

Catra does her best to roll her eyes in her current form. Adora snickers and leans down to press a few kisses to her head, smiling when Catra pushes up into them. "Okay , you guys should go." She sets Catra into the box set aside for this purpose, with water for the journey and a few runes drawn on the sides.

Bow scoops it up and with a final goodbye, they're on their way . Glimmer wraps her arms around Adora's shoulders and squeezes her tightly as they watch Bow drive off. "What do you say to a girl's night? We can head into town, get some shitty frozen pizza and boxed wine? It'll be just like college!"

Adora laughs, though she knows it must be obvious that her heart isn't in it ,and agrees. So, they grab jackets and keys and get in Adora's car. They get to the market in no time and Glimmer follows her inside. She isn't prepared for the sight that greets her in the frozen food aisle but forces herself toward Shadow anyway .

Every bit of the rage and heartbreak she summons up for this interaction is genuine, though her words are about to be false. Glimmer murmurs her name warningly under her breath as she marches down the aisle. She just shakes her head shortly . She'd been planning to do this anyway, really drive the final nail into the coffin. She just hadn't planned on it being so public, but maybe that's even better. Let her be painted as the uncontrollable, scorned lover.

"*You*." She barks when she's just a few paces away from the infuriating monster.

Shadow Weaver turns slowly, her face a mask of smugness and derision. "Why *Adora*, manage to find your little pet yet?"

The angry tears that spring into her eyes are genuine, and she makes no effort to hold them back. She comes in closer so she can whisper viciously. "You absolute wretched witch! This is all your fault."

"My dear , your inability to keep control of that…*animal*," her smile grows sinister at the name calling. "is no one' s fault but your own."

Adora laughs without humor. "Sure, maybe. But the fact that she' s *dead*, that blood is on *your* hands." She notices Shadow' s eyes widen minutely before she hastens to cover it. t' s a good sign, a sign Adora is managing a convincing performance for once in her life.

"have *absolutely* no idea what you are talking about."

Adora wipes her tears roughly and Glimmer puts a steadying hand on her shoulder, sqeezing once. "Sure you dont. And Ill just bet you have no idea how how the," She hiccups, again, it' s not hard to fake. She's not even sure if it counts as faking at this point. "how her fucking *body* ended up in the creek *right by my house*, do you?"

The vile woman before her does little to attempt to hide her surprise this time. She lowers her voice to match Adora's tone. "*You horrible little bitch*, what are you saying?"

"m *saying* Shadow, that Iwill find a way to make you pay for your crimes. Idont know how , but someday Iwill come back here and Illl make you *regret* what you took from me."

Now Weaver grasps the lapel of Adora's jacket. "ey! Hands *off*." Glimmer bites out.

Weaver lets go but her posture remains unchanged. "Are you *certain*, absolutely certain it was her."

Adora snarls. "Fuck of f."

"D you have any idea what you have cost me? Y ou think Iwould do this? She is worth nothing, *nothing* to me dead." W eaver sucks in a breath and pulls back. "Best of luck in your sad little life *Adora*, Ill tell you one thing at least; if she *is* dead, your life is better for it."

Adora clenches her jaw. "I've already spread her ashes. She's gone, and she's never coming back." Internally Adora revels at the horror on Shadow's face at this announcement. Whoever she's done business with, attempted to sell Catra's life to, Adora hopes they make her *pay*.

"Adora, honey, we should go." Glimmer encourages.

"Yeah," Adora nods, doing her best to collect herself. "yeah, I'm done here. For now."

She gives Weaver a final withering look, wrenches a freezer door open to grab the first couple pizzas she can get her hands on, and spins on her heel. After that it doesn't take long to gather a *copious* amount of boxed wine and get out.

She collapses into the seat of her car and finally, finally exhales. Rain is now pouring down in sheets and Adora flips on the windshield wipers to fend against it. It only helps so much.

"Damn Adora," Glimmer breaks the silence after a stretch. "I'll be honest, I didn't think you had that performance in you."

Adora sighs. "Yeah, well." She says no more before starting the car and driving them home. She is more than ready to bust out that box of wine.

…

The following day they wake up hungover and lethargic. They manage little more than plain toast for breakfast so by lunchtime both Glimmer and Adora are *hungry*. Her friend offers to piece something together while Adora works on cleaning in the spare room and she accepts gratefully.

She's scrubbing the baseboards when her phone rings. Her heart stops when she sees Bow's name. She wastes no time in answering

it. "Bow? How are you? How is she? What's happening? She wasn't gonna change back until later today!"

"Adora," His voice sounds strained and Adora's heart clenches. "I need you to stay really calm for me, okay?"

"Yeah Bow," Her voice is shrill, and she knows it. She doesn't care. "No chance of that. What's going on?"

He sighs and the sound seems to bring him no relief. "Okay, there's no reason to panic yet, okay? There was a small accident." Adora gasps into the phone, her heart stops completely. "Just a fender bender; I got out, exchanged information with the lady, everything was chill."

"But?"

Another heavy sigh. "But she's not in the box, Adora."

"*Bow, where is she?*"

"I'm not sure, but I really don't know what could have happened. We're in the middle of nowhere on the side of the road, no one else is even *around*."

"*Fuck!*" Adora's shout brings Glimmer into the room. She tries to mime a question to Adora, but she waves her off.

"Hey, still no reason to panic, okay? I'm gonna look around the area near the car and we're gonna find her."

"Shit, shit, shit! What if someone got into the car Bow? Fuck, what if she's gone? I don't even know how to start *looking* for-" And now she's officially hyperventilating.

"Uhh, Adora?"

"Fuck, I really thought we had her fooled, you know, I just-"

"Adora!"

"*What* Bow?" And then she hears it, a tiny little mewl filtering in from the background.

Bow speaks off to the side. "Catra, you scared me! What happened bud?"

Adora registers another little mewl, so familiar her heart shatters and meds itself all at once. It begins to cautiously beat again, and Glimmer resumes her miming. Adora waves her off once more but chances a meek smile which seems to pacify her for now. "She's okay?"

"She looks fine! She was under the seat is all. No idea what she was doing there, but I'm sure she'll be able to tell us when she's back to herself. Won't you bud?"

Adora wipes away tears of relief. "Fuck, okay. Wow, I'm th...anks, Bow. Sorry I freaked out on you."

"Totally understandable." He answers calmly. "If I'm being honest it was really hard to keep a level head for you." Adora chuckles wetly. Muffled, she hears Bow laugh and tell Catra, "Yes, it's Adora. But can you stop- ugh, lesbians." Then he's back. "Your girlfriend is purring and rubbing on the phone and-ow! Hey, she bit me!"

Adora makes a face that only Glimmer, still mostly clueless, can see. "Uhh...sorry Bow."

"It's fine, I think she just wants to...talk to you? Okay, yeah that seems to be it. I'm gonna starts driving again, but I'll put the phone on the seat so you can talk to her, okay?"

"Sounds good, thanks again Bow." Then a loud purring filters through the line and she giggles, just slightly hysterical. "Hey Kitten, I'm just gonna fill Glim in real quick, okay?"

The little meow she gets back sounds a little miffed, but she takes it as agreement. Quickly she gives Glimmer a recap that has her rolling her eyes and disappearing back into the kitchen to finish their lunch. Then she's speaking back into the phone.

"Hey Kiten, stars you scared me! I wish you could tell me what that was."

More purring filters through the line.

"Okay , well later then." Adora sighs heavily . "I miss you; it' s only been a day. I feel so useless."

A little sniff meets her ears and makes her smile.

"Be nice to Bow okay? He' s helping us out, remember?" She laughs. "I can't believe you bit him."

The next little mewl sounds slightly af fronted.

Adora sighs heavily. "I'm just so glad you're still there, that you're okay. I hate this part; I hate that I can't be there with you. It' s gonna be worth it though, right?" She pauses considering if now is the time to bring this up. It feels like semi good news though, so she pushes forward. "I saw W eaver."

That gets a hiss that makes Adora laugh humorlessly.

"Y eah, same. I think I. I think she thinks you're *gone*, gone, though. I'm so glad you're not. Fuck, okay , I'm gonna start talking in circles without you to break me out of them. I just.. stars, Catra I think I almost had a heart attack. The feeling I might have lost you.. I'm so tempted to say it, Kiten; I feel so sure right now . I just not like this, right?"

Catra's purrs through the phone are nearly deafening now. Adora stays silent a moment, soaking in the sound.

"Soon though, well be together soon."

Later Bow will tell Adora that Catra falls asleep, purring, on top of his phone. For now, Adora just listens to the sounds of it, and the soft pattering of rain that begins to fall outside the house.

…

Adora really wishes Bow could have stayed behind instead of Glimmer. Though if she's being honest, it's probably for the best; Catra and Glimmer are *far* too similar and probably would have torn one another to shreds before they even made it to Brightmoon. Still, at least Bow can clean properly. Adora doesn't *mean* to be critical, and Glimmer can handle normal day to day tidying up just fine. But deep cleaning? No way.

She's a big help on Monday morning; organizing the movers who come to take what Adora has left to be put in storage on the other side. Glimmer was, after all, born to be bossy. Everything else though? Adora is pretty much on her own. It's nice to have Glimmer to keep her company at least, Adora is certain she'd be tearing her hair out if she was all alone. And if nothing else she's is down to make trips to the market to ensure their stock of wine and frozen meals never runs too low.

She's also good for reminding Adora how short her time apart from Catra really is. She keeps it light, teasing, calling Adora a clingy lesbian. There's never any real bite to her words though, she seems to be aware that it's not the being apart that has Adora on tenterhooks. The real issue is her total lack of control, the inability to do anything to keep Catra safe.

Finally, *finally*, Friday evening rolls around; Glimmer and Adora will be leaving first thing in the morning, just as soon as Adora hands off the keys to the real estate agent. Adora is ecstatic to be getting on their way but also, their imminent departure has put in harsh perspective the goodbye she's about to say.

Glimmer finds her in the kitchen in a similar position she found herself the first night she met Catra. She's at the kitchen island,

staring morosely at the oven. Rain falls steadily outside the window.

How many pies has she made in that oven? And how many more had Razz made? Will the new owners tend to the garden, love it like Razz had? Will they tear down the wallpaper in the master bedroom, with the tiny roses and faded pinstripes, that Adora had been allowed to help pick when she came for the summer at nine years old?

"Hey pouty , what are you doing in here?"

Adora sighs, unable to get it up to match Glimmer's teasing. "Just… thinking."

Glimmer purses her lips and comes to sit on the stool next to her . "Saying goodbye?" Adora nods. "Listen, Adora I know this might be a day late and a dollar short but, are you sure you're making the right decision?"

Adora's instinct is to instantly defend her choice, to defend Catra because she knows that's at least part of what her friend is getting at. However , something gives her pause, she considers the question with the weight it probably deserves. "I am, yeah. There's so many memories in this house but I can't live here just because I miss her , you know?"

"Yeah." Glimmer reaches over to put a comforting hand on her knee, her eyes are all pity and heartbreak and comfort. "That makes sense."

"It's just sad." Adora shrugs, long since having accepted that fact. The loss of Razz, and with it the loss of the sense of home she used to find in this place, is always just going to be a sad thing. All Adora can do is refuse to dwell on it. "It's the right choice, I know that. It's strange to think I'll never come back here though."

Glimmer slides off her stool to come up next to her and wrap her tightly into a hug. Adora leans into it and accepts every ounce of

comfort she is offered.

In the morning, with hope in her heart, it doesn't feel so hard to say goodbye.

…

The drive is endless, even split between her and Glimmer it takes two days, with a night in a motel in between. Bow and Catra call to check in the second morning as they get on the road. They keep it brief but Catra says she's settling in well. She's staying with Bow until they arrive and for the first night with Adora.

After that she'll be staying with her friend in the city until she gets on her feet, paying rent to take her spare room once she's able. Adora wants to insist that she's totally welcome to stay there with her, but she knows that's not what this is about.

As much as she wants Catra with her, to see with her own eyes each morning that she's safe, she won't ask Catra to forfeit her independence the moment she's free. She also seems to be genuinely excited to spend time with Scorpia, who had left their hometown several years ago.

By the time they reach the city Glimmer is cranky and looking forward to sleeping in her own bed. She's very vocal about both. Adora barely listens; she's so excited her ears are ringing. She rubs her eyes at every stoplight, exhausted from taking the final shift of their drive. If she can just make it a little bit further…

Finally, she pulls up to the building Bow and Glimmer had moved into after graduation. A vibrant sunset is reflected in the windows, the air unseasonably warm. She's out in a flash, only bothering with her bags at Glimmer's insistence.

"Adora, stars alive, we've got mere moments to go; you'll survive."

Adora huffs, practically running up the stairs to the third floor. "I know that Glimmer, I'm just excited. Cut me some slack, will you?"

"Ugh, whatever . Just- here take my key . I'm not running up there with you." Adora darts back down half a flight to take the proffered key ring. Then she's off, tearing her way up the stairs and through the door.

And there she is, safe and sound, sitting on a couch Adora herself has spent countless hours on. Bow's head snaps up at the sound of the door, he's next to Catra on the couch. Some show is on the background, Adora hasn't the presence of mind to register what it is.

Catra turns, her movements more languid. A slow smile unravels across her face. "Hey Adora."

Bow clears his throat and stands, half blocking Adora's view. She tries not to be irritated. "Where's Glimmer?"

"Stairs." Adora answers, breathless from her flight up the stairs. "Too slow."

"Right." Catra snorts and Bow nods slowly , making his way toward Adora. He glances back at Catra when he makes it to the door . "I'll just go um, help her with her bags"…

He pulls the door shut behind him and Adora drops her bags where she stands. She's over the couch and has Catra in her arms in an instant. She wastes no time in kissing her deeply, passionately, as she exhales all of her anxiety from the past week.

One hand goes to Catra's cheek and the other holds her hip firmly. Catra squeaks in surprise at the suddenness but quickly melts into Adora's touch. Her opposite hand cradles Adora's cheek and she grips Adora's shoulder with the other. Out of breath, from the kiss and never having caught it after getting to the door, Adora pulls back and rests her forehead against Catra's.

"Damn," Catra breathes. "I miss me that much?"

Adora laughs. "You have no idea." She crushes her into a hug. She's holding her tightly, as if to assure herself with every one of her senses that Catra is *here*, Catra is *safe*.

Catra allows it for a minute but eventually pushes herself free, not allowing Adora to stray too far. She pulls them down onto the couch and laughs when she catches Adora staring at her, reverent. "I missed you too, you idiot."

"Wow. I can't believe we did it; it's over."

Catra grins. "Yeah, Adora I really-I can never thank you enough for what-"

"I love you."

Catra's eyes snap open wide. "O-oh okay, damn."

Adora smirks at her surprise, she could not possibly have made this any more obvious. "Catra?"

"Hm? Oh, yeah, right. I love you too. Ahem. But you knew that already."

Adora laughs and shrugs. "Still nice to hear."

Their next kiss is interrupted by their friends making their way inside. They take long enough that Adora suspects Bow has talked his girlfriend into giving them a moment; despite it delaying her reunion with her bed. She appreciates it more than she has words to express.

Still, Glimmer manages to shatter the moment the second she's in the door. She walks in with a hand over her eyes and announces, "We're coming in! And Bow said he made dinner, so we better not be interrupting anything; I'm starved."

Adora opens her mouth to retort but Catra stays her with a hand on her arm. She fakes a gasp. "Oh, shit babe! Better get your shirt on quick."

Adora snorts at the growl Glimmer lets out as she whips her hand away from her face. She rolls her eyes when she sees them sat on the couch, a little pink but hardly on their way to getting hot and heavy. "Ugh, remind me why you're here."

Catra waggles her eyebrows. "Because Adora *loves* me."

"Alright you two," Bow cuts in. "play nice. Glim can you like." He gestures with her bag, asking for admittance into the apartment. She steps out of the way and he deposits her bag in their room

Bow and Catra have blessedly gotten dinner ready to go, so they're able to sit down as soon as the new arrivals get cleaned up. Adora digs into the best curry she's ever eaten. "Bow! This is so good."

He shakes his head. "All Catra actually . She was so excited about it; she took all week to decide what to make."

Adora's "A ww." is drowned out by the clattering of dishes when the table shakes. Adora's pretty sure Catra's kicked his shin or something based on the hard breath he sucks in.

"*Dude*."

He smirks over at her and tries for innocence. "What?"

"You're the literal worst."

"Oh. W as I *not* supposed to tell Adora about how you've been g-"

Catra cuts him off with a growl. "I will rob you of your first born and lock them in a tower like that witch from Rapunzel if you do not shut up right now."

“A w, babe. You miss me or something?” Adora coos at her . Glimmer cackles at Catra’s obvious discomfort and Bow just smirks, clearly proud of himself.

“Shut up. Y ou missed me too.” She points her fork at Bow . “And you. Let’s not pretend like you weren t pining even harder than I was all week over Shimmer here.” Bow shrugs, unashamed.

“Can you at least call me by my name in my own home?” Glimmer rolls her eyes.

“Sure thing, Glitter .” She huf fs but gives up easily. Adora has known Glimmer long enough to suspect that some part of her thinks the teasing is funny.

Knowing how exhausted Adora and Glimmer are they retire as soon as dinner is cleaned up. Bow and Glimmer head to bed and Adora sets up the pullout for Catra and herself.

They lay together in the dark room, noses practically touching. “I really did miss you.”

“Y eah, me too, Dora.” She sounds exasperated, but fond.

“How was it here? With Bow .”

“Bow’ s chill, weird to be cooped up in someone else’s unfamiliar apartment though.”

“Y eah.” Adora of fers a half smile. “Thanks for waiting up for me.”

“Course.” A yawn cuts her of f from saying much else.

Adora catches it, blinking sleepily. “Okay , I could talk to you all night, but also I might pass out right this moment.”

Catra rolls her eyes, Adora can just see the glint of it in the dark. “Go to sleep dummy, I ll still be here in the morning.”

Adora hums happily. "Mkay ." She drifts of f to sleep, for the first time snuggled back into Catra;the little spoon.

…

Scorpia might be the nicest person Adora has ever met, maybe even nicer than *Bw* . More effusive at the very least. They meet when Adora takes Catra over and she welcomes them both into the apartment with a big bear hug. Catra grumbles but the crinkling at the corners of her eyes tells Adora it's just for show . Something Scorpia seems to be well aware of seeing as it doesnt fa e her a bit.

She invites them in for tea and cookies and Adora notices that Catra looks *comfortable* here. They relax into their chairs and Adora eats the best shortbread cookie she's ever had, bar none. "So how long have you guys known each other?"

"Me and Wildcat? Gosh, since we were little kids. Basically forever!"

"W ow, so much to unpack there. First of all;Wildcat?"

Catra groans and Adora's smile turns wicked. She buries her face in one hand, the other still holding Adora's tightly, to block it out. "Dnt you start. Scorpia only gets away with it because well, Ihavent been able to get her to stop and it's been twenty years now. So."

Scorpia smiles fondly at Catra over her teacup. "A w, geez Wildcat, you know me so well!"

"Okay , Scorpia, what was Catra like as a kid?"

Catra groans again and slips down into her chair. She doesnt look comfortable. Scorpia laughs good naturedly. "Oh, she' s always been a firecracker! She had a biting phase."

Adora snorts loudly, barely managing to keep her tea in. "*Excuse me?* A biting phase?"

"Oh yeah, must have been, what? First grade or so. She'd try and get the other kids to play zoo with us. Then she'd insist on being the tiger and-"

"Okay! Scorp. I think she gets it."

"Aw, I bet you made a cute little tiger."

Catra rolls her eyes. "Yeah well. That was right around the time the kitten started coming out. Transitioning back and forth was weird and Weav-ahem, uh I was practicing at home a lot." She blushes and both Scorpia and Adora soften with understanding. She mumbles, "I liked having an excuse act like a cat or whatever. At school."

Reading the room Adora makes an effort to move them along. "Okay, what about junior high/high school? Did she have an awkward phase? I bet you totally got gangly."

Catra snorts and sits up in her chair. She's still sort of sprawled across it but she look comfortable at least. "You do realize I've seen photos of you from junior high, right?"

"Right, and I haven't had the pleasure. So, gangly phase?"

Scorpia laughs. "Honestly? No, Catra was always really strong from all the climbing. Just moody."

"Sounds about right." Adora turns to give Catra a moony eyed smile and gets a fond eye roll in return. Soon Catra directs the conversation away from her childhood toward lunch. They eat a nice meal together and then Adora is helping Catra get situated in the spare room. Her room.

It's fine, she reminds herself as she drives away. It's not like she'll never see Catra. Besides, this is the whole point of this year; for Catra to assert her independence and figure out what she wants. Adora ignores the nagging anxiety in the back of her mind that tells

her that maybe, at the end of the year, what Catra wants won't be her any more.

…

Adora waits in line at the coffee shop. She knows what she wants by the time she makes it to the till, but still she taps her chin and considers the menu anyway.

"I don't know." She glances down at the barista, expression schooled into something serious. "What's good here?"

Catra rolls her eyes but they remain warm. "Literally nothing." She ignores the weird look her manager gives her. "You should probably just leave."

"Hmm no. I heard there's this *really hot*, super *gay* barista here who makes *the best* drinks. Could you point me in their direction? Maybe they can give me a good recommendation."

At this Catra laughs loudly. "Fuck *off*, Adora. I know you're just gonna get the same damn thing you always do."

"Aw." Adora's tone stays teasing but under it she genuinely softens. "You know my coffee order?"

"Yeah, well. Twelve-ounce caramel latte isn't exactly hard to memorize."

"Yeah, but you still know it. Almost like you *like* me or something."

"I do *not*-look, shut up now and you can have my shift drink, okay?"

"Yeah, no I'm paying. But I get it, I'll let you get back to work."

They bicker a little bit but ultimately Adora doesn't pay. She does leave a twenty-dollar tip, which Catra glares at, however. So that makes her feel better.

She walks out with her drink ten minutes later with a delighted spring in her step. The air is crisp and cool with the beginnings of winter, but the sun shines warmly on Adora's face. "Idiot" is branded across the side of the cup where her name would typically be.

Adora is happy.

…

By the time Adora finds a place of her own she's ready to not see Glimmer and Bow for a couple weeks, at least. She still loves them, of course. So much! And she'll continue to be eternally grateful for their support. It's just been three weeks of living with a couple in their one-bedroom apartment; they're *all* ready for some space.

Catra isn't able to be there to help move what Adora needs out of storage, but she comes by after her shift. The café where she's been working is just a few blocks from Adora's new apartment. Not that the location influenced Adora's pick, definitely not.

After peeling off her warm layers, she flops on Adora's unmade bed with a groan. "It's fucking freezing out and I smell like stale coffee."

Adora crawls up next to her and buries her nose in her neck, nuzzling in. "I think you smell *good*."

Catra scoffs at that. "Think you might be a little biased there, babe."

"Hmm no I think you just objectively smell good." Catra groans and shoves her away.

"Whatever. Is your shower set up enough I can sneak one in before we eat?" Adora nods and digs up a towel for her. While Catra cleans up, she orders Thai food from the place she frequented before her impromptu move to the country.

She didn't bring Razz's old couch, so they set up a picnic on the living room floor and tuck in. When they cuddle up for bed,

exhausted from their respective days and just a touch wine drunk, Catra falls asleep quickly. Adora takes a little longer, fighting off melancholy at the thought of all the nights to come where she'll be falling asleep alone.

The thought makes the cozy one-bedroom apartment feel far too large for just her. She knows this year is important, for Catra and for their relationship, but she doesn't love it. She respects that Catra wants to be independent, that she's wary of U-Haul-ing and fucking this up. It's just that they've already lived together, and she meant what she said about never wanting to have to relearn what it's like to fall asleep without Catra.

It's fine though, totally fine. She should *maybe* consider drinking less wine though. It always seems to make her moody.

…

A couple months later Catra picks Adora up at eight. They start their night at one of Adora's old haunts; a space themed bar that does dollar jello shots on Friday nights. They're pretty weak but by the time they leave, they've each had enough to make them unsteady on their feet.

"Hey!" Adora yelps out of nowhere, leaning on Catra who's leaning on her.

"You're drunk."

"Well yeah, but that's not what I was gonna say."

Catra, just slightly more coordinated, weaves them around a group of folks walking in the opposite direction. It makes Adora stumble and she presses more firmly into her. She doesn't pull any further away once she's steadied herself.

"Whacha gonna say babe?"

"Wait, hang on." Adora stops them in the middle of the sidewalk, effectively making them an obstacle for everyone else out on the town. She puts one hand on Catra's shoulder and the other on her cheek. "I'm sit. s cereal-serious."

Catra raises an eyebrow and sways slightly in place. "Okay, I'm listening."

"I.. *love* you."

Her girlfriend bursts out laughing and Adora watches her fondly. "Yeah, well just wait till you've seen me do dancing, baby."

And she's right, by the time they're back at Adora' s apartment she's fallen even deeper in love. Maybe it was the carefree look on her face beneath the bright lights and the disco ball. Maybe it's the forceful way she's pressed Adora to drink three glasses of water before they go to bed. Maybe it's the way that Catra, when drunk, gets snuggly in a way that so reminds Adora of the kitten.

The *why* isn't so important though. All that matters is the certainty that settles in Adora's bones; Catra is it for her.

…

Adora is grumpy today. She's been back at her old job-well the position below her old job at the same company- for four months now. It' s just as awful as she remembers it being. After two months of sitting around she figured she might as well be bringing some money in. Now, she's not so sure.

She hates it there and her and Catra's schedules often don't align so they're barely seeing each other. And, for the past two weeks or so, every time they do, they bicker. The weather has been moody and wet, slush on the streets icing over each night. Catra's snapped at her about it more than once during their spats. ("Fuck Adora, can you get your emotions under fucking control? I bit it and bruised my ass on the way over here. *Again.*")

She's at her wits end at this point; Catra just got to the apartment and it's like she's *trying* to pick another fight.

"Can we just not tonight? *Please*."

Catra scoffs at her appeal. "Can we not *what*, Adora?"

She scowls at that, she hates when Catra does this. "Not fight, not bicker. Just I haven't seen you for three days and I know we're both pooped, but I…"

"What? You're worn out so I should just pretend everything is fine?"

"That's not what I said!"

"It's kind of what you said." She uses that fake bored tone she likes to pull out. Adora's sure it's just to get under her skin. Unfortunately, it works every time.

Her jaw flexes. "Why are you so?…"

"*Excuse me?* Why am I so what?"

"So intent on having a shit night!"

"I don't want to move after a year!" Catra's eyes go wide and she slaps a hand over her mouth. Adora freezes, hell, every molecule of air around them seems to freeze in the wake of Catra's declaration.

"Oh." Adora pauses, unsure what comes next. And then, of its own volition, the next thing that pops out of her mouth is, "I'm gonna get dinner started then."

She lags behind a second but Catra follows her into the kitchen. "I what? You don't even want to talk about what I just said? Adora?…"

Adora cuts her off with a hand in the air. Without looking at her once, she ducks into the fridge to start collecting ingredients. There's no game plan, so she just pulls out a lot of random crap.

"Can you just give me a second?"

"Fine." Catra crosses her arms and plops herself down on the far end of the counter, to the right of the sink. The sight makes Adora soften just a little bit. She starts peeling carrots.

Once she's onto mushrooms she finally finds her voice. "How long have you been feeling this way?"

Catra shrugs, neither of them makes any attempt to meet the other's eyes. Catra watches her own swinging legs and Adora fixates on her vegetables. She's already cut enough veg to feed a small army. She starts on the zucchini.

"A couple months but I only really figured out exactly what it was I've been feeling the last couple weeks."

Adora nods and pulls out a pan. She sniffs and insists to herself that there's no reason to cry. It's fair if Catra needs more time. It's just… "I thought ahem, I thought we were gonna reassess after a year?"

"We are we were. I just, I'm working at a fucking coffee shop and I still don't know what the fuck I'd do in the *country*, you know?"

Adora purses her lip and nods. She resists the urge to tell her that there's coffee in the country too. It's very clearly not that simple. "I understand."

"You do?" She sounds hopeful and Adora blinks back tears. She sets her knife down and finally turns to look at her girlfriend. She's looking back at her, sat up properly with wide hopeful eyes.

"I do." Catra tips her head. Adora's voice is still somber. "I think I have to leave at the end of the year though."

"*What?*"

Adora sighs and leans back against the counter. She stares at a framed photograph of her and Razz making pies. She must have

been twelve or so. Catra's eyes continue to bore into her.

"I left for a reason Catra. I hate it here; I'm fucking miserable unless I'm with you or my friends. It's not working for me. I'll stay the full year but after that…"

Catra laughs, it's a hard, angry sound. "What? After that it's your way or the highway?"

Adora shakes her head and wipes away the tears that track down her face. "No. I don't expect you to leave if you aren't ready." She turns back to look at her. "But just as much as I can't ask you to leave if you aren't ready, I need you to not ask me to stay if it's going to make me unhappy."

Catra's face morphs from something fierce and angry to something far more desperate. It feels much heavier on Adora's heart. "Well… then what does that mean? What if you quit your job? That's half of why you're so miserable, isn't it?"

Adora nods, but it's not enough. "I've been thinking about it. But without that I need something to *do* all day. How is me having not job and waiting around for you or my friends any different than you having no prospects in the country? I want *land*, Catra. I want to garden and to sit outside at night and see *stars*. I'm ready to put down roots, and I don't want to do that in the city."

Catra is crying too now and if anything, she looks even *more* desperate. "Well, so what does that mean? For for us."

Adora shrugs; "that's the whole problem, isn't it? Do you Catra, do you *ever* want to leave the city? It's so okay, it's fair if you don't. I just think maybe it's better if we know that now."

And Catra looks afraid. "I don't know." She whispers. "I've never lived anywhere like this before and I- it's still so novel. I like going out dancing, I like that there's every kind of restaurant I can imagine and

then some, I like *uber*. It sounds nice, what you're saying. I miss the stars and the nature."

"But you don't know if you want to go back." It's resigned.

Catra shakes her head though. "I just can't say *when*."

"Six months." It's more a thought aloud than a statement.

"On your lease?" Catra clarifies gently. Adora nods slowly, holding her eyes. Catra holds her arms open, and she takes the invitation, wrapping her tightly in a hug. Catra's arms wrap around her back and her legs around her hips.

After staying like that for a long while, Catra releases her legs and turns her face into Adora's neck to whisper, "How do we compromise if our positions are mutually exclusive?"

"I dunno, I'm tired."

Catra nods into her. "I don't know if the city is worth losing you."

Adora releases a single choked sob. "You won't, it doesn't have to… we can do long distance."

Catra deflates at the suggestion and pulls back to look at her face. "That sounds terrible if I'm being honest."

"Oh." Her voice is small, scared.

"I already feel like I barely see you."

"Yeah, I get that."

They share a sigh and just stare at each other for a bit. Finally, Catra breaks the silence. "Will you please hug me again?"

With no hesitation to her movement Adora does as is requested of her. Catra wraps her up in all of her limbs, clinging to her tightly. She

doesn't release when Adora uses the position to lift her up and carry her to the bedroom.

She does, however, allow Adora to lay her back on the bed. She allows Adora to kiss her reverently, everywhere. Whether it's a promise or an attempt to memorize this connection before it's lost is a question Adora isn't willing to answer that night.

Maybe tomorrow.

…

Bow and Glimmer have hosted a barbeque to celebrate summer every year since they moved into their apartment. They hold it on the building's rooftop and go all out with food and decoration. It's always fun but with Catra here, laughing with their mixed friend group, it feels like home.

"Bow!" Catra calls across the deck to their friend manning the grill. "Do you have any actual drinks?"

He turns, the hand holding is tongs propped on his hips. "What's that supposed to mean?"

"Ugh, it means I don't want to drink bitch beer all night. Hard seltzer and lemonade? Seriously?"

"Hey Wildcat!" Scorpia interrupts, arm slug across her new boo's shoulders. "Did you try the tangerine? *Very* refreshing."

"Babe!" Bow calls, turning back to tend to their food.

Catra flips to cooler shut and groans. "I'm not fucking drinking that. You know how much sugar is in that shit? Y'all are gonna be hungover as shit tomorrow."

She looks around and spots Adora at the table beside Scorpia and Perfuma. She's watching her, eyes dancing with laughter. "I told you

we could stop by the store on the way.” She teases before Catra can even open her mouth.

She groans loudly. “Where the fuck is Glitter? I know she has something harder than this in that apartment.”

Adora laughs. “Yeah, I think she said something about making margaritas. She should be back soon.”

“Fuck yes!” Catra cheers. Then, requiring no invitation, she crosses the deck to throw herself into Adora’s lap. “Fuma, how’s the shop? Scorp said you had some big wedding coming up.”

Perfuma groans and tugs at the end of her long braid. “Yes, and the bride keeps changing her mind between peach and blush roses. And her mother”…

Without taking her eyes off her ranting friend, Catra lifts Adora’s bottle of hard lemonade to her lips and takes a long drink. Adora just smiles at her and shares a look with Scorpia. It’s a perfect day, the sky is blue as far as the eye can see and everyone is in high spirits.

Something unnamable rises in Adora’s chest and her heart swells. It’s a good day today.

…

Catra starts taking classes at the community college fall quarter. Adora has just shy of three months left on her lease. She takes Catra out to celebrate after her first week of classes and neither mentions the implications of the timing. Instead they eat sushi until they’re ready to burst and drink sake until the room spins, just a little bit.

Adora half carries her sweet, drunken college student home and puts her to bed. When she wakes up the next morning, somewhere between feeling rough and being truly hungover, Catra is still asleep.

She looks so peaceful. Her dark hair is splayed out across the white pillowcase, her lips barely parted to let out little puffs of her breath, and her face is smooth and free of worry. Sun trickles in through the curtains, warming Catra's face, making it glow softly. The kitten flashes though her mind, all the mornings Adora woke up to Catra curled up on her pillow. If she had known then…

Catra blinks her eyes open slowly and a small smile unfurls across her face when she finds Adora watching her. "Hey baby."

"I'll wait." Adora whispers.

Catra makes another attempt to blink the sleep from her eyes and frowns ever so slightly. "Huh?"

"For you, forever."

Another hard blink and Catra sits up, looking down to Adora who remains laid down with her head propped on her hand, lifted by her elbow. "What are you saying?"

"I-"

"Ugh, and why are you saying it *before* coffee?"

Adora sits up too and takes Catra's hands in her own. "If you still want me here, with you, I won't leave the city without you."

That shocks her, the emotion evident on her face. "*What?* Adora, I-"

"I mean it, Catra; I won't, I don't want to. Can I make one request though?"

Slowly catching up, Catra breaths, "Anything."

"Move in with me? Now, or if you want to wait the full year, we can find a place that's *ours* when my lease is up. Whatever you want, just- *please*?

"Adora." Her voice breaks, and then she's crying.

It's not exactly the reaction Adora imagined. Though she'd made the declaration somewhat on impulse, having let the thought simmer in the background for weeks now. So, she hasn't exactly imagined that many scenarios. Still, this one hadn't come up.

Catra tips herself so that her head rests on Adora's shoulder until she tires herself out. She sits up again, wiping her face. "Are-Are you *sure*?

"I'm completely certain. I don't want roots unless you're growing with me." Catra begins to cry in earnest once more. "Baby is.that-is that still what you-"

"*Yes!* Are you fucking-yes, of course it is." She bites her lip and searches Adora's face. "I've been thinking."

Adora sits up a little more with interest. "Oh yeah?"

Catra bites her lip. "I don't know where you were thinking about buying land…"

"But?"

"But Eternia U has a really good computer science program. I was thinking once I got my AA…"

Adora's heart starts to race. "Eternia is beautiful…"

A smile teases the corners of Catra's mouth. "Yeah, it is. I did a little research; land out there is pretty cheap too. If I save up for a car before we move I could commute from outside the town proper."

And now Adora's racing heart melts. "You did research?"

Catra takes her hands. "I want you Adora, and I… *fuck*, everything you've done for me and now you're gonna just wait for me. I-"

"Hey, nuh-uh." Catra's face scrunches in confusion. "For *us*. We're a team, right?"

She rolls her eyes; her smile is now so wide it could split her face in two. "Yeah, we're a team. So, the very least I could do for the *team* is a little research."

"Computer science?" Adora asks, a little surprised. Most recently Catra had been talking about pre-law.

"Yeah, well. Turns out I'm decent with computers and shit. Plus, I have no interest in dragging this college thing out, so grad school's out, and well, you can use that degree from pretty much anywhere." She looks equal parts shy and proud. It's very attractive.

Catra drags Adora out of bed an hour later, demanding breakfast. She's only too happy to oblige.

The sun is bright in the kitchen, and for the first time in months the future seems bright too.

Chapter End Notes

Hi hi hi!
This chapter has been about 3/4 written since before I started The Drama of It All which was supposed to be a little side thing (I mean, so was this. Really, who am I kidding at this point lol.) but I finally circled back!
I'll be honest this chapter got more of a skim than a proper proof read, so if there's more errors than usual...that's my b.
There's gonna be one more chapter and I have a vague outline for that so maybe it won't take another three weeks to get it out, who can say really? Final chapter will be sort of epilogue-ish.
Annnnd...that's all I have for ya!
Thanks so much for reading and for folks leaving comments and kudos! I appreciate you so much!

At Our House

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora looks warily at the seat next to her. "Catra can't be too mad, right buddy?"

No response.

"I mean it would be *pretty* hypocritical. If I can do it for her, why not you?"

The cat on the seat beside her rolls onto their back, looking bored.

"And look how good that turned out! I mean, if I do say so myself."

The cat rolls over again and looks at her with just a flicker of interest.

"Besides, what's she gonna do? Make me take you back?"

The cat harrumphs.

"She would never right?"

The cat flops back on their back again, a light purr rumbling from their chest. Yeah, this is gonna be totally fine. Adora mostly believes that.

Catra is out on the balcony of their second story apartment when Adora pulls up. It looks like she's watering their little potted plants, but she's easily pulled away from the task; she looks up the instant Adora is out of the car. She shuts Melog inside for now. "Hey Princess! How was work?"

"Work was fine. How was your day?"

Catra narrows her eyes. "My day was good. Why are you being weird?"

Adora scoffs, it sounds awkward even to her. "I've been out of the car for ten seconds; how can you even tell if I'm being weird?"

"So, you admit, you're being weird." She walks right up to the balcony railing and leans against it, looking down at her partner.

"I never said that." Catra starts looking around for clues and Adora moves to cover the driver's side window with her body. She winces when she sees Catra register the move.

"Yeah, but you didn't deny it. Same difference."

"Fine. Maybe."

Catra smirks and raises an eyebrow at her. There's laughter in her eyes. "Adora"…

"Just keep an open mind, okay?" When Catra's second brow raises Adora opens the car door. She scoops up the cat snoozing away on the front seat and presents the sleepy little dude to her girlfriend.

"Holy fuck! Adora!"

She bites her lip and grimaces. "Look, I know I should have said something, checked in with you first. But like someone brought them in this morning and they just- I can't explain it. It was like this gut feeling."

Catra holds up a finger and disappears inside. Adora waits nervously for her to emerge from the building; it only takes thirty seconds or so, but it feels like ages. Without acknowledging Adora, she holds her arms out for the cat.

They willingly move into her arms and chirrup quietly, settling in. Immediately she hugs them to her chest and kisses the top of their

head. She looks up at Adora with a smirk "Did you really think I was gonna be upset about this?"

Adora smiles indulgently at the sight. "I mean no, but still, I should have asked. We move in a week; I know the timing's not great."

Catra rolls her eyes and moves into Adora's personal space. With Melog cuddled up between them she leans over to kiss her cheek. "Dummy, it's fine if you know what I'm gonna say anyway. What's their name?"

"Melog." At Catra's strange look Adora puts up a hand in surrender. "Hey, that's the name they came with."

Catra's expression shifts into something thoughtful. "Hey, I have a question."

"Okay." Adora leads them toward the apartment entrance; she's ready to be out of her work clothes, she smells like animals.

"What were you gonna do if I *was* pissed?"

Adora winces and tromps up the stairs. At the door she pauses to look at Catra, her eyes tight. "Uhh wing it."

"You're an idiot." Catra deadpans.

Adora shrugs and lets them in. "I mean, your idiot." She stops short once inside. "*Catra*, how much work did you do today?"

She slips past her and sets the cat down on the couch. Immediately they begin exploring, methodically snif fing and scent marking everything in the room. "Eh, finished the kitchen, the books, uhh… some other random stuff." She shrugs.

"Kitten, it's your last day off before we move, and I don't work all week. Don't you wanna relax?"

"Meh, nothing else to do really , since you got called in to cover. All our fun shit's packed up."

"I mean, you did pack our books today . Books are fun." She' s mostly just being sassy . They'd both been disappointed when Adora' s boss had called and asked if she could cover for a sick coworker down at the animal shelter.

Of course, as much as she was disappointed, she was glad to have an extra day at work. Her last day was supposed to have been two days ago and she'd already been missing it. After deciding to stay in the city until Catra got her degree, Adora knew she had to quit her shitty office job or risk going insane. She'd taken the job at the shelter just for something to do with her time, until she figured out what she wanted to do long term. Naturally, she'd fallen in love with it. After that she just stayed.

"I can't read." Catra deadpans. Adora just snorts at her .

"Yeah, okay. Do we still have dishes or are we gonna start ordering in?"

"Eh, I left us the basics. I don't feel like cooking though and I'd be into Thai tonight if you are."

"Works for me." Agreed on that Adora pulls out her phone to place the order. The place they like is just a few blocks away and since she'd never gotten around to taking off her shoes, she offers to pop down there.

She comes back to just about the cutest sight ever . Catra has built a nest of blankets on their couch and is sat in the middle. Melog is slowly inching toward her, sniffing her outstretched fingers, from the edge of the blankets. She can't hear her words but Adora can her Catra mumbling softly to them.

Quietly she closes the door behind her and sneaks further into the apartment. She leans against the wall and watches for a few

minutes.

Finally, Catra says at a normal speaking volume, "You know, even if I hadn't heard you come in, I can still smell the food, dummy."

Adora startles. "Well, can you really blame me? You two are adorable."

"Shut up, you're adorable." She finally turns away from the cat once he scent marks her hand and curls up by her legs.

"Aw, shucks." Catra snorts. "Hungry?"

"Famished." Adora gets plates from the kitchen and Catra makes room for her in the little nest.

She looks around the small apartment they've been sharing for about two years now. It really became a home in that time; *their* home. It looks so barren now though, with everything packed away. Gone are the tiny dishes Catra put around when she grew weary of finding Adora's hair ties *everywhere*. The landscape Catra had painted in her art class her third quarter (which Adora loves, but she insists is amateurish) has been wrapped in brown paper.

All the things that have made this place home for so long; packed away and ready to turn a new space into a new home. A little nest where they can roost for the rest of their lives.

-I-

Catra drives the U-Haul most of the way. Adora insists she can help split the drive, but they're really not going far, and she *knows* it makes her anxious. Her stomach starts fluttering at the first sign they pass with the exit for Eternia on it.

She can barely believe her life right now. She's gay, she's in love, she's college educated, and the love of her life just bought them a damn *house*. College student and cottage core lesbian Catra; if

you'd told her two and half years ago that this would be her life… she'd probably have decked you to be honest.

But she's here and the instant she pulls up to the house she knows she's *home*. A lot of the house is woefully in need of updating, but the land has been well tended by the family they bought it from. There are a few beautiful apple trees in the back, and the wisteria growing along the trellis that hangs over the porch and driveway has clearly been there a very long time.

What had really sold Catra though, is the massive, gorgeous White Ash tree in the front yard. It must have been growing upwards of a hundred years and it's just amazing. Catra can't wait to climb it, and apparently Melog can't either. The minute Adora opens her door they're out in flash and up the tree.

Catra gets out and circles the truck to look up at them. She loves that damn cat. When Adora had left them alone the first time they just bonded. She's never had a pet before, and she wonders if it's always like this; an instant, inexplicable soul level connection she'd protect at all costs. Either way she couldn't be happier that Melog is in her life now.

Adora sneaks up beside her and wraps her arms around her waist, tucking her chin into her shoulder. "We did it, we're home."

Catra hums with a big smile. "We still have to unload the truck." She murmurs.

Adora nuzzles in further. "Can it wait a little bit?"

"You don't want to just get it over with?" That had certainly been Adora's sentiment when they moved into the apartment.

She shakes her head and Catra doesn't see it so much as she feels it. She makes a little sound of disagreement and whispers in Catra's ear, "No, I wanna snuggle and make out with you on the porch swing."

And *that* is exactly what they do.

-I-

Catra is going to be home from class in half an hour and Adora's *almost* ready, but not quite. She just needs to hustle. She spent too damn long laying a fancy lattice for the pie. *But* , to be fair, the ornate flowers and leaves around the edge do look amazing. Hopefully Catra thinks so too.

When they realized their fifth anniversary would fall on a day Catra needed to make it to class, they agreed celebrating that weekend would do just fine. And it will. Adora just sees no reason they can't do a little of both, and a nice dinner to welcome her partner home seemed simple enough.

She just still needs to get the lasagna in the oven, get changed, set the table, and lay the petals she got to lead from the front door to the back patio. It's twenty-seven minutes. It's fine, Adora's fine. It's a bit of a mad dash at the end, but Catra's ten minutes later than she planned for so she manages to pull it off.

Catra emerges from the back door, smirk on her face and the single rose Adora left with a note on the front door in her hand. "You're ridiculous, Adora Grey."

Adora scrambles to stand from her chair, taking a moment to smooth out her pants and suitcoat, with an earnest smile on her face. "Happy Anniversary, Kitten."

Catra walks closer, setting her flower on her place setting, and wraps her arms around Adora's neck. "Thought we were waiting for Saturday?"

"We are, I just figured it'd be nice to do a little something on the actual day too."

Catra leans in to give her lips a quick peck. "You're sweet. Should I go change?"

"Only if you want! You look beautiful."

Catra scoffs and rolls her eyes. "I look like I just took a pop quiz and did three people's worth of work on a group presentation. Gimme ten minutes."

"Take as long as you need, food is staying warm in the oven." She sits back in her chair while she waits, looking up at the stars and listening to the crickets in the distance and the soft rustle of the breeze.

When Catra emerges from the house again ten minutes later, she nearly swallows her tongue. She's wearing the crimson suit she'd gotten for Bow and Glimmer's wedding, but she's not wearing the shirt she'd gotten to go with it. She's not wearing a shirt at all actually, just a black, lacy bralette.

"You're drooling, babe."

"Yup, sounds right." Catra's smirking but Adora doesn't miss the slight flush that rises to her cheeks at her affirmation.

"Alright, charmer, you ready to eat?"

Adora gets their food, and their wine, and they settle in to eat. It's nice; they talk a little more about Catra's day, and then move on to the projects they want to do on the house. Adora's convinced she can figure out how to retile the kitchen on her own. A few years ago, Catra would have argued with her, but she's been proved wrong too many times since they bought the house. Adora is surprisingly handy.

After lingering over empty plates for a while, Adora rises to fetch the pie, but she pauses before picking up the plates. "Hey Cat."

"What's up, beautiful?"

"I really love you."

Catra's expression softens to the point of melting and she grabs Adora's arm to pull her into her lap. "I really love you too."

"I love our life."

"I love our life too, baby."

"Do you think…"

"Hm?"

"Marriage, babies… we haven't talked about that stuff in a while."

Catra sighs deeply and Adora instantly regrets bringing it up. She does love their life, and she truly wouldn't change a thing. Would she maybe, possibly be interested in adding a thing or two? Sure. She doesn't need it though, and the last thing she wants to do is push. She gets ready to back pedal but Catra speaks up before she's able.

"Adora it's my senior year. The timing…"

"I don't mean now!" She tightens her arms just a bit where they lay on Catra's neck. "Shit, I'm sorry. I just meant in the future."

Catra purses her lips and considers the woman on her lap. Her expression is set to something serious. "I don't give a shit about marrying you." Adora tips her head and raises an eyebrow at that. Catra rolls her eyes. "I just mean, I *already feel* married to you. If doing the thing is important to you…"

"Yes?"

"Fuck Adora, whenever and however you want. We can go to the courthouse tomorrow morning. Or I'll propose in some romantic gesture and we can plan a big thing, have a huge party here at the

house or something. I'm happy to marry you babe, I just don't need it."

Adora nods, mulling that over. "Okay . And the other thing?"

"I'm scared."

Adora's brows knit together in concern. "Scared? Scared of what?"

"I don't know how to be a fucking *mom*, Adora. I didn't even ever *have* a mom, let alone a good one. And the world is so fucked up and scary do I really want to bring a kid into that?"

"Oh, Kitten I think you'd make a great mom." Catra scoffs at the notion and Adora frowns. "No, really . I mean, I don't really know all that much about being a mom either but you already take such good care of me. Why should a kid be any different?"

"Yeah, well, you don't shit in your pants."

That effectively breaks some of the tension and Adora laughs. "Not yet, but we still gotta take care of each other when we're old and back in diapers. And the other thing; what if we adopted? Or fostered even. We don't have to bring new life into this world to be parents."

Catra tips her head to the side, clearly considering the idea. "I… that's better. Than some fresh ass baby. I don't think I have an answer for you right now though."

Adora smiles softly and leans in to kiss her temple. Catra smiles and leans into the touch. Lips still against her skin, Adora mumbles, "That's okay, I don't expect you to. Just think about it, we both can, and we'll just keep the conversation going until we figure out what works for both of us." A little nervous she pulls back and bites her lip. "Sound good?"

"Sounds perfect."

-1-

"*Finn!* I swear if you don't come out here right now"…

Adora emerges from the laundry room and smirks at her irritable wife. "What have they done now?"

She spins to face her properly and growls. "We were playing hide and seek, and I can't fucking find them. It's been an *hour*, I'm getting worried."

"Ah." Adora looks more amused than concerned. It's fucking pissing Catra off. Their *child* is missing. "I think I know what happened."

She crooks her finger and, totally bewildered, Catra follows her into the laundry room. Relief floods her at the sight that meets her there. In a basket of warm towels, a little orange kitten is wrapped around Melog's back.

Unwilling to let her ire go, Catra grumbles. "They fucking know shifting is against the rules. Fucking cheat and scare me half to death on top of it"…

Her eyes sparkling, Adora smiles and asks, "You gonna wake them up?"

"Ugh, no. I don't want to see their fucking face right now. We're grounding them for a *month* when they're back though. Hell, make it six months, a full year even." Moving to fold some clean clothes, where the basket of towels and kittens is still plainly in sight, Catra continues under her breath. "Try and cheat against mom? Just see what happens you fucki-"

"Catra! Enough with the language."

She rolls her eyes. "They're *asleep*, Adora."

"Or pretending. We've already been talked to by their teacher once, and I *know* you hate going in for that."

"Well why does she have to scold us like *we're* the children? I'm not the one who cursed in her classroom."

Smirking with an eyebrow raised in challenge, Adora corrects her. "Well, actually you *did*."

"Well I'm a fucking adult, I can say whatever the hell I want."

"Whatever you say, kitten."

Catra looks back at the basket. They *are* cute. And if she's being honest, the fact that transitioning is so comfortable for Finn warms her heart. The relationship they've formed with Melog because of it even more so.

Since finding and adopting another shapeshifter, Catra's started trying to morph into the kitten more often. It's surprisingly easier. So much so she's begun to wonder if something about the environment has an effect on the ease of transition. She thinks it will probably always be a little hard on her body though.

Adora joins her effort to fold the clean clothes. As they finish, the orange kitten stretches and lets out a big yawn. Catra will not let herself be endeared before she's given her lecture. At least not *too* much. Slowly they morph into the cute little kid they'd met just a couple short years ago. Bigger now, but big blue eyes and bright blond hair just the same.

Catra sort of likes how much Finn looks like Adora. Of course, she couldn't give less of a shit about having a biological link between them and their kid. Still, it's a pretty picture all the same. As they sit up and stretch, Catra throws a pair of shorts and a tee shirt at their head.

They blink slowly at her and smile bashfully. "Ohh hi mommy."

"Uh-uh, no way kid." They pout and get their shirt on, forgoing their pants for now. Kids are fucking weird. They wiggle out of the basket,

pissing Melog off in the process, and cuddle into Adora's side. She just watches her family in amusement.

"Sorry ."They mumble, half muf fled by their mama's hip.

"Are you? Do you understand why I'm upset, why I got so scared?"

Their lower lip wobbles and they nod their head. "Cause I'm not supposed to."

Catra sighs, her anger finally melting away. She kneels in front of her kid and shakes her head. "Nah Finn, it' s not just because you broke the rule. It' s okay to question the rules sometimes, but I need you to understand why we have this one."Finn tilts their head and Catra looks up at her wife, unsure if she's looking for backup or just encouragement. She gets the latter in a soft, emotional smile.

"When you're little like that it can be really hard to find you. So, if something scary happens Mama and I need to know to be looking for the kitten instead of our big kid. Does that make sense?"

They nod, but they don't look very comforted. "I cheated."They confess, like Catra might not have figured that out.

Catra snorts and their little eyes go wide. "Y eah, well. Cheating's not very nice, and you shouldn't do it with your friends, but can I tell you a secret?"They nod emphatically , already looking a little less upset. She leans in close, darting a quick look to Adora who rolls her eyes. Then she whispers, "I always beat Mama at cards because she doesn't hide them so good, which makes it really easy to cheat. It' s okay to cheat a cheater *sometimes*."

"Catra!"Adora admonishes her above Finn' s little giggles. She shrugs, unrepentant. If she doesn't like it, she should learn to stop showing off her damn cards.

Still not finished, Catra addresses Finn again. "Y ou can shift at home any time you want Finny, you just gotta tell Mama or I first, okay?

And maybe not during hide and seek unless you tell me *before* you hide."

"Okay Loggy wants ta climb the tree when they wake up." Catra raises an eyebrow. They'd figured out early on that the two had some odd form of communication, inexplicable but undeniably effective. Still, it's sort of odd to have your kid interpret for your cat.

"Sure, you wanna shift for that?" They nod. "Okay , just tell one of us when you're gonna go out, okay? We ell sit outside with you."

"Loggy wants you ta come too, your kitty ." Catra sizes them up shrewdly. About as quick as they'd figured out their baby and their fur baby could communicate; Finn had figured out they can *lie* about what Melog has to say.

"Loggy does, or you do?"

Finn shrugs. "Both." And if Catra' s heart doesnt just turn to mush…

"I'll think about it."

"Okay! Imma color till Loggy wakes up. They're sleepy ."

"Sounds good, kid." They scurry out from under Adora' s arm and rush off, still pantsless.

Catra stands again, groaning at the ache in her knees. Adora is still watching her fondly so she walks up to her and pulls her into a hug. "You're cute." Adora mumbles into her hair .

"Shut up, I'm not cute."

"Hm, hate to disagree."…

"Pft, no you dont."

"No, I dont." Catra pulls back to look at Adora' s smug, cute little face. "I love you."

"I love you too."

"You're a good mom."

Catra snorts. "Yeah, our kid's a little shit though."

"You love them."

"I do." She looks at her wife, really looks at her, and her heart swells. "Hey, have I thanked you recently?"

Adora's face scrunches up with confusion. "For what?"

Catra shrugs. "All of it; loving me, *saving* me, waiting for me, our house, our amazing life."

"Catra." Adora's voice breaks and she wipes a tear from the corner of her eye.

"I mean it, Dora. I'm so grateful for you."

"I'm grateful for you too, Catra. For loving me, saving *me*, coming for me, our kid, our amazing life." They hold each other tightly at that and Adora begins to slowly rock them from side to side.

Melog slips out at some point and Finn comes to collect Catra. She shifts with them and Adora comes out to watch them. She sets up with tea and a book and settles in on the porch swing. Catra runs to the end of a branch and looks down at her through the branches.

It hits her full force, not for the first time, that this is her *life*. Their amazing, strange, beautiful life. And she can hardly wait to live the rest of it.

Chapter End Notes

Woo! Finished a story, look at me go!
Might actually let myself start another now lol (but maybe I'll finish my two other WIPs first...whoops)

Ihad such a fun time writing kitty cat Catra, thanks to all reading this and to folks sharing their thoughts in the comments!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!